

The "Mökki" Experience: The Role of Authenticity and National Identity in Finnish Cottage Accommodation

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Abstract:

Authenticity and experience-driven travelling have been central themes in tourism research in the 21st century. Although authenticity has been studied in tourism studies for decades, certain areas have remained under-researched. This study examines the role of authenticity and Finnish national identity in cottage accommodation. Because cottage accommodation has deep cultural and historical roots in Finland, this study aims to offer new insights into how authenticity and cultural elements are experienced within the cottage environment. The study focuses on international tourists' perceptions, interpreted through the experienced insights from tourism guides. The research is conducted as a qualitative study using semi-structured interviews. The dataset was analyzed by using abductive thematic analysis. The findings highlight the significance of Finnish cottage environment and lifestyle, local culture, symbolic meanings, and emotional experiences in perceiving and shaping authentic Finnish cottage experiences. Furthermore, the interpretation of authenticity is shown to depend on an individual's cultural background and personal interpretation. The study also identifies potential threats to the authenticity of travel destinations posed by mass tourism and overdevelopment.

Itä-Suomen yliopisto, Yhteiskuntatieteiden ja kauppatieteiden tiedekunta
Kauppatieteiden tiedekunta
Matkailumarkkinointi ja johtaminen
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Tiivistelmä:

Autenttisuus ja elämyskeskeinen matkailu ovat 2000-luvun matkailututkimuksen keskeisiä teemoja. Vaikka autenttisuutta on tutkittu matkailutieteessä jo vuosikymmenten ajan, tietyillä aihealueilla tutkimusta on tehty suhteellisen vähän. Tässä tutkimuksessa tarkastellaan autenttisuuden ja suomalaisen kansallisidentiteetin roolia mökkimajoituksessa. Koska mökkimajoituksella on Suomessa syvät kulttuuriset ja historialliset juuret, tämän tutkimuksen tavoitteena on tarjota uusia näkemyksiä siitä, miten autenttisuus ja kulttuuriset elementit koetaan mökkimajoitusympäristössä. Tutkimus käsittelee kansainvälisten matkailijoiden näkemyksiä, joita tulkitaan ulkomaalaisten matkaoppaiden havaintojen perusteella. Tutkimus on laadullinen ja sen aineisto on kerätty puolistrukturoiduilla haastatteluilla. Tutkimusaineisto on analysoitu abduktiivisen temaattisen analyysin avulla. Tulokset nostavat esiin suomalaisen mökkielämän ja elämäntavan, paikallisen kulttuurin, symbolisten merkitysten sekä tunnekokemusten merkityksen autenttisen mökkielämyksen kokemisessa ja muotoutumisessa. Lisäksi tutkimus viittaa siihen, että autenttisuuden tulkinta on riippuvainen yksilön kulttuuritaustasta ja henkilökohtaisesta tulkinnasta. Tutkimus tuo esiin myös massaturismin ja liiallisen rakentamisen muodostamat potentiaaliset uhat matkailukohteiden autenttisuudelle.

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Declaration of AI Assistance

During this thesis project, I utilized an AI-based application (ChatGPT) as a help for planning the structure of the thesis and during the analysis to draft the code needed to clean up the material, which was then modified and specified by the author of the thesis. Additionally, an AI-based proofreading application (Grammarly) was used at the end of the work for checking the grammar mistakes. All arguments, interpretations, analyses, and conclusions presented in this work are my own, and I take full responsibility for the content of this work in its entirety.

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1 Introduction

1.1 Background and research gap

"Welcome to Luosto!
Small, idyllic, and authentic resort in the heart of Lapland in Sodankylä, only 90 minutes from Rovaniemi airport. Come and explore the untouched nature in the Pyhä-Luosto national park, and visit the unique Lampivaara Amethyst mine.
Luosto is about warmth, immediacy, safety, forests, authenticity, Northern Lights, and different colors of the sky. At Luosto, you will notice how good it is to be small.
(Visit Pyhä-Luosto, 2025)

The citation above is posted on the home website of Luosto, a small Finnish tourist destination in the middle of Lapland, capturing some of the key trends in the tourism research field in the 21st century. Personalization, sustainability, and experiential travelling with new digital innovations and technologies are at the heart of current tourism research (Ferrer-Roca et al., 2020; Loureiro & Nascimento, 2021). People are seeking authentic and unique experiences from nature, historical and cultural scenic spots, and other various destinations (Cheng et al., 2023; Lu et al., 2022; Ram et al., 2016). Especially, nature-based tourism, wellness tourism, and ecotourism have been rising in the late decade (Fredman & Lusine, 2021; Liu et al., 2023; Loureiro & Nascimento, 2021), and at the core of these trends are the authentic experiences and respect towards local people and nature.

Authenticity, nature-based tourism, and experiences are also a great part of Luosto's brand. Many Nordic tourism resorts, including Luosto, are based on their magnificent natural assets, wildlife, and nature-based activities, such as skiing, fishing, motoring, and hiking (Fredman & Lusine, 2021). Experiences play a key role in creating unforgettable memories and the authenticity of a destination. Authenticity has been one of the debated topics in the tourism

research field, but especially in the late decade, research on the subject has exploded (Rickly, 2022). One of the original definitions of authenticity was introduced in 1973 when MacCannell (1973) proposed a perspective that authenticity refers to people's ability to create an impression of genuineness through the display of local culture in the tourism field. Later, many other perspectives (Cohen, 1988; Bruner, 1991; Wang, 1999; Steiner & Reisinger, 2006) broadened the definition and meaning of authenticity. For example, Wang introduced a view where authenticity is not seen only as an object-related concept but also as an experimental and activity-based concept (Wang, 1999). In Finnish tourism research literature, authenticity has been studied relatively little, especially in the context of accommodation. Cabin accommodation is a significant part of Lapland's accommodation offering, and every year thousands of foreigners come to Lapland to spend their holidays and to stay in various and unique cabin destinations. (Visitory, 2024)

The relationship between "Finnishness" and authenticity is also an under-researched topic in the tourism context. It is unclear how tourists perceive authentic Finnishness and what factors are influencing its construction. In this study, Finnishness is approached as a concept that is constructed from various themes, such as public discourse, stereotypes, the media, and other sources. Second homes, specifically summer cottages, are also strongly associated with Finnishness, and they have long roots in Finnish history, national identity, and culture (Periäinen, 2004). The study offers a completely novel approach to the hospitality sector, as the significance of authenticity and national identity in the context of cottage accommodation has not been studied together before.

This study aims to investigate how authenticity is perceived in Finnish cottage accommodation and what elements are perceived to contribute to an authentic Finnish cottage experience for international tourists. Additionally, this study could offer ways in which these factors could be utilized in future studies and in the development of the hospitality sector in Finland. The literature research is based on Pine & Gilmore's Experience economy (1999) and Wang's (1999) authenticity theories with the perspective of Finnish culture and "Finnishness". The data for this study were collected by interviewing Central European guides who work with their international

clients at the Luosto resort during the winter season 2025-2026. Although empirical data is collected from guides, international tourists represent a conceptual target group. The analysis focuses on tourists' perceptions, which are interpreted through the professional observations and experiences of guides. Luosto is a suitable and appropriate destination for this study because of its diverse selection of cottages in a traditional Lapland tourist environment. It represents several key elements of Lapland's tourist destinations: snowy winters, Arctic nature and weather, nature activities, the Northern Lights, and so on.

This study positions itself within the growing body of authenticity research in tourism, with a specific focus on accommodation experiences. Previous studies have explored authenticity in hotel and Airbnb contexts (Akarsu et al, 2020; Mody & Hanks, 2020; Kwon et al, 2024), while little attention has been given to cottage accommodation, especially within the Finnish tourism landscape. Therefore, the relevance of this study is to provide a new perspective on perceived authenticity as a competitive factor in cottage accommodation and international tourism more broadly, to raise awareness of the importance of cottage accommodation in the tourism industry, and to provide management tools for improving marketing in the cottage accommodation sector. A deeper understanding of the cottage experience could help develop cottage tourism in Lapland and other parts of Finland, also during the low seasons.

1.2 Previous studies

Authenticity has become an increasingly common topic in tourism research, and the number of studies has grown exponentially over the past decade (Rickly, 2022). However, the relationship between Finnish cottage accommodation and authenticity has not been studied before. Since the field of authenticity research is relatively broad, this study examines the phenomenon primarily from the perspective of the tourism and accommodation sectors, with a particular emphasis on Finnish cottage accommodation and its connections to national identity. In general, the authenticity of accommodation settings is often studied in other forms of accommodation, such as luxury accommodation (Hanks et al., 2024; Manfreda et al., 2024; Kwon et al., 2024), sharing economy accommodation, such as Airbnb (Paulauskaite et al., 2017; Akarsu et al., 2020;

Mody & Hanks, 2020), and the hotel industry (Mody & Hanks, 2020; Kwon et al., 2024). These studies have, for example, highlighted the role of authenticity in influencing the consumer decision-making process (Paulauskaite et al., 2017), fostering brand loyalty (Mody & Hanks, 2020), and enhancing life satisfaction (Kwon et al., 2024). However, none of these studies have examined the factors related to national identity and authenticity together within the accommodation context.

The combination of Finnishness, authenticity, and cottage accommodation is a unique theme, and there are no existing studies made of this subject. Since Finnishness itself has not been studied extensively in the field of tourism, this study focuses on examining Finnish culture from a broader, interdisciplinary perspective. For instance, historical perspective is discussed to understand Finnish national identity and cultural development (Aslama & Pantti, 2007; Paatela-Nieminen, 2016; Raento, 2008; Onali, 2024). At the same time, aspects of popular culture (Kärki, 2021; Aslama & Pantti, 2007), language (Hjelm et al., 2019), and advertising (Pietilä et al., 2019; Pulkkinen et al., 2023) provide insight into Finnish values, habits, and cultural expressions. For example, Pietilä et al. (2019) studied how mythologies of Finnishness can be seen in advertising, and Tillotson and Martin (2015) examined how social and cultural myths become part of organizational structure and status.

It is important to view Finnishness from an international tourist's perspective and consider how Finland is marketed and branded globally. It can be assumed that the information tourists receive about Finland plays a significant role in shaping their perception of authentic Finnishness when they visit the country. Common topics in Finnish tourism research in recent decades have included, for example, Santa Claus (Pretes, 1995; Hall, 2008), sauna (Tillotson et al., 2021), Finnish nature and sustainability (Johansen & Konu, 2025; Sorakunnas et al., 2024; Cornelisse, 2019), and Sámi culture (Saari et al., 2020; De Bernardi, 2022). These topics provide clues as to how Finland is perceived and what attributes are associated with Finnishness, such as closeness to nature, the cultural significance of the sauna, the magical imagery of Santa Claus, the heritage and traditions of Sámi culture, and strong environmental values related to sustainability. For example, Visit Finland, the national tourism marketing organization, plays a key role in

promoting sustainable development in the Finnish tourism industry, aiming to position Finland as one of the most sustainable tourist destinations in the Nordic countries (Sorakunnas et al., 2024).

The last major literature theme in this work is Finnish cottage culture. Cottages and second homes are strongly attached to Finnish history, culture, and mythology, and they also have a long history in other Nordic countries. However, cottage and second home culture is a rather under-researched tourism field from a customer experience perspective, especially in an international tourism context. Some international research exists (e.g., Hannonen et al., 2015), but the majority of existing studies focus on cultural, geographical, or historical perspectives. For example, research topics in domestic context have included geographical and environmental factors of cottage culture (Pitkänen & Rantanen, 2023; Hiltunen, 2007), cottage mobility in Finland (Hiltunen & Rehunen, 2014) historical and cultural aspects of cottages (Häkkänen et al., 2022a; Pitkänen, 2011; Vepsäläinen & Pitkänen, 2010), the connection between cottages, mythologies and national identity (Periäinen, 2004), the role of cottage among Nordic countries (Müller, 2008), and the role of cottage culture now and in the future (Poikolainen, 2022; Pitkänen & Vepsäläinen, 2008). Although authenticity has been part of tourism research for decades, current cottage research literature only contains references to this concept. The cottage research does not specifically address the significance of international tourism either; instead, the discussion has been more general or focused on domestic tourism. This creates a gap in the field of cottage tourism research, and as a result, the significance and potential of cottage accommodation open an avenue for research.

1.3 Objectives and research questions

Since limited research has been conducted on rural areas in Lapland, particularly from the perspective of cottage accommodation and authenticity, the aim of this study is to narrow this academic gap. The goal of this research is to understand how international tourists, through the perspective of tour guides, perceive Finnish authenticity in cottage accommodation in a Finnish tourism resort called Luosto. By identifying the factors that make cottage accommodation

unique and authentically Finnish, the study aims to find ways to utilize these factors in the development of services and accommodation. By understanding the motives of tourists, the tourism industry can be developed and expanded more effectively, also at other times of the year outside the high season. Because the winter season in Lapland is operationally intense and tourists stay only briefly, direct access to international visitors for in-depth interviews is limited. Therefore, this study uses experienced Swiss guides as expert informants who observe and interact extensively with international tourists during cottage stays. Guides act as cultural mediators and are able to report tourists' reactions, questions, expectations, and interpretations.

The Research questions of this study are:

RQ1: How do international guides perceive and interpret international tourists' sense of authenticity in cottage accommodation in the Luosto region?

RQ2: What elements are perceived to contribute to an authentic Finnish cottage experience for international tourists?

1.4 Research context and positioning

This work is positioned in the intersection of *authenticity research, tourism marketing, and Finnish cottage culture*, filling a gap because authenticity in Finnish cottage accommodation has not been studied before. The theoretical base of this study is on customer experience research, more specifically on Pine & Gilmore's (1999) theory of Experience economy. This study aims to examine the tourist's perspective of authenticity as a subjective and experiential process, therefore the authenticity theory by Wang (1999) is adopted. By combining Wang's authenticity theory with the concept of Finnishness, this study contributes a new cultural and experiential dimension to the understanding of authenticity in rural tourism. Because it would be shortsighted and restricted to think that authentic experiences would be constructed only from an existential authenticity perspective, the objective, constructed, and postmodern views are also taken into consideration and evaluated in this work. The heart of this work is to understand

how international tourists perceive authenticity and Finnishness in cabin accommodation and to find connections to already existing research. Positioning of this study is visualized in Figure 1.

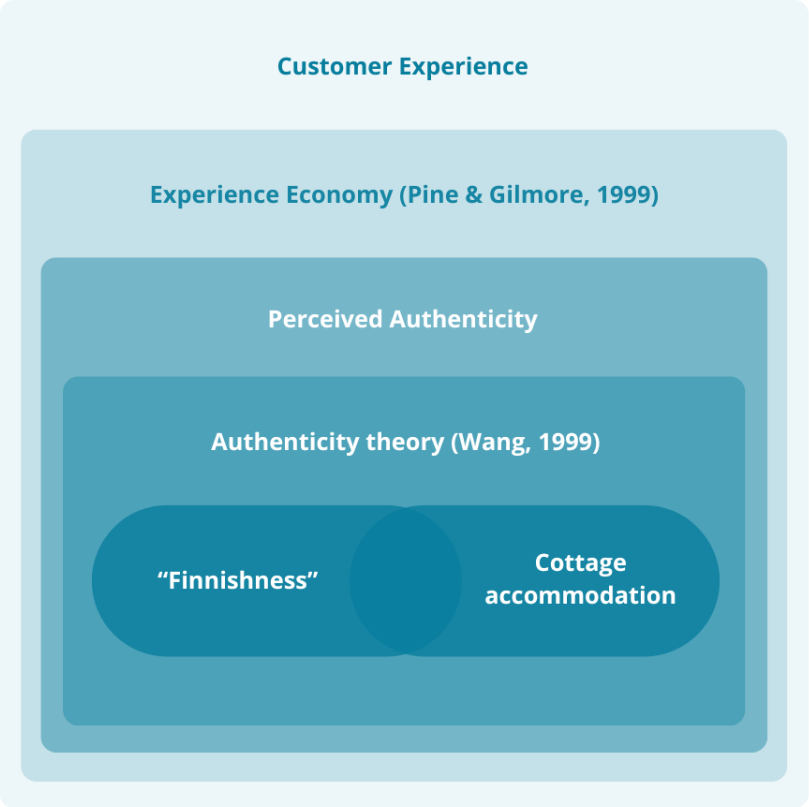


Figure 1. *Positioning of the study.*

1.5 Key concepts

Experience economy is a concept developed by Pine and Gilmore (1999) to describe a shift in economic value creation. According to them, economic development has progressed through four stages – commodities, goods, services, and experiences, with the experience stage representing the current phase, in which consumers are looking for meaningful and unforgettable experiences. The authors conceptualize experiences into two different dimensions: the level of how much consumers participate in the experience (actively or passively) and the type of connection they have with the experience (absorption or immersion). Based on these dimensions, they proposed a model with four sub-dimensions: entertainment, esthetic, educational, and escapist, collectively known as "4Es." (Pine and Gilmore, 1999)

Customer experience is a concept that can be understood as the customer's emotional, social, cognitive, and physical reactions to a company, and it is composed of factors that are both under and outside the retailer's control. (Verhoef et al., 2009). Tourism experiences can be approached through different models and perspectives, but they all emphasize the connection to customers' emotions, desires, and personality traits. Walls et al (2011) argue that experiences are formed within individuals, which means that the ways they are constructed vary according to each person's values, previous experiences, and personal patterns of perception. The concept of *experience* is widely used in several academic fields, including sociology, psychology, anthropology, ethnology, economics, and marketing. (Walls et al., 2011)

Authenticity is a concept that has been studied for several decades, and many different perspectives (Boorstin, 1992; MacCannel, 1973; Cohen, 1988; Wang, 1998) have been proposed to define it. Authenticity usually refers to words real, original, true in substance, first-hand, reliable, or produced in the same way as an original (Ram et al., 2016). It can be divided into objective and activity-based authenticity (Wang, 1999). Objective authenticity focuses on defining the "originality" of objects, while action-based authenticity explains experiential authenticity, also known as existential authenticity (Wang, 1999).

Cottage, also known as "mökki" in the Finnish language, is a concept that refers to the second homes of Finnish people. In this study, the terms "cottage", "cabin", and "second home" are used synonymously. A cottage refers to a privately owned building located in a rural area for recreational purposes, with amenities ranging from simple to very good (Hiltunen, 2007).

Finnishness, in this study, is understood as a socially and historically constructed identity that consists of elements such as shared cultural symbols, historical events, narratives, myths, and popular culture. Finnishness is treated as a dynamic and subjective concept that is constructed based on the information and experiences collected and received by individuals.

1.6 Structure of the thesis

This work consists of five chapters. The first chapter has introduced the background, key concepts, and objectives of this research work. Also, the previous studies have been introduced shortly, and the positioning of this study is visualized, describing the study's position in the current research literature. The second chapter covers three broader theoretical themes: (1) authenticity in tourism and cottage research, (2) conceptualizing Finnishness, and (3) the history of cottage accommodation and its connection to Finnishness. The third methodology chapter introduces the research method, data collection process, and analysis. Also, the background (and analytical data) of the research site is presented. The fourth chapter summarizes the results and findings from the study. Finally, the fifth chapter discusses the main findings and conclusions in light of the theoretical framework. Additionally, limitations, critical evaluation of the study, and future research suggestions are presented. In this thesis, the AI tool ChatGPT (used in autumn 2025) was used to plan the structure of the thesis. The author is responsible for all the content and has checked its accuracy in full.

2 Theoretical framework

2.1 Authenticity in tourism research

2.1.1 Authenticity as a trend

Authenticity is one of the debated and oldest subjects in the tourism industry (Rickly, 2022). For decades, there has been discussion about what is truly authentic, how authenticity can be defined, and whether its presence, or perception, ultimately matters in the tourist experience. As the tourism industry moves toward a more ecological, sustainable, and environmentally conscious future, travellers are increasingly seeking ways to travel while respecting and supporting local communities. Consequently, sustainability, experience-driven travelling, and authenticity have become more meaningful. (Pololikashvili, 2025)

On a broader scale, other trends in the tourism industry strongly support people's motivation to seek authentic experiences. For example, slow tourism, wellness tourism, and sports tourism are all on the rise, and the common factor in these trends is a focus on people's experiences (Lu et al., 2023; Chen et al., 2022; Takata & Hallmann, 2021). Sustainability issues, health motivations, and digitalization are one of the biggest factors shaping the tourism industry in the 2020s, and authenticity is strongly linked to these trends. For example, slow tourism is about escaping the fast-paced lifestyle and focusing on the present moment and well-being, reducing consumption, and enjoying nature (Lee et al, 2024; Meng & Choi, 2016). Slow tourism refers to a form of tourism in which travellers take their time on their trips and connect with local people and places (Dickinson & Lumsdon, 2010), and authentic experiences are naturally closely linked to this trend.

It has been noticed that travellers are increasingly seeking more experience-driven and authentic experiences during their travels, rather than commodity-based goods (Tussyadiah & Pesonen, 2016). Oh et al. (2007, 120) argue that in the tourism and hospitality industry “everything tourists go through at a destination can be experience, be it behavioural or perceptual, cognitive or

emotional, or expressed or implied". Tussyadiah & Pesonen's (2016) study examined the travel motivations of people from the United States and Finland who use peer-to-peer accommodation and found that travellers desire more meaningful interactions with local people and activities in authentic environments.

Many studies of authenticity focus on heritage tourism (Domínguez-Quintero et al., 2019; Lin & Liu, 2019; Lee et al., 2015) as it is associated with items and places that are considered authentic and original. This view, where the authenticity of an object is evaluated by experts and where copies or replicas are seen as inauthentic, is called objective authenticity, which was the first presented definition of authenticity in tourism research by MacCannell in 1973. Later authors began to criticize this rather narrow and limited view of authenticity, which led, for instance, to the rise in popularity of activity-based authenticity theories (Wang, 1999). Activity-based authenticity, also known as existential authenticity, is based on people's experiences that feel meaningful and authentic, even if the object itself is not "original." For example, if a person participates in a yoga retreat in Bali and feels a genuine connection to themselves and the local culture, the experience is authentic, even if the locals consider the product to be staged and commercial.

Authenticity is shaped by people's perceptions, experiences, and emotions of authenticity (Cohen, 1988; Wang, 1999) and not only by the originality of an object. Therefore, it is important to discuss how experiences and authenticity are examined together and how authentic experiences are related to experience economy theory. In the next chapter, experiences and authenticity are observed in more depth through the lens of experience economy theory by Pine & Gilmore (1999).

2.1.2 Authenticity and the Experience Economy theory

Perceived authenticity depends on a person's feelings and experiences; therefore, it is essential to discuss how experiences are generated. Pine and Gilmore introduced the theory of experience economy in 1999, where they proposed an idea that economic development has

evolved through four stages: the first stage as the commodity exchange stage, the second as the commercial economy stage, the third, the service economy stage, and the last and current stage, the experience economy stage. They theorized that people are looking for unforgettable experiences in the experience economy stage, rather than only intangible and customized services, which are provided in the third stage of the service economy (Pine & Gilmore, 1999). Therefore, various tourism operators are challenged to develop new ways to offer experiential products and services that create memorable and unique experiences (Chi & Han, 2020; Hwang & Han, 2018).

To illustrate the Experience economy stage, Pine & Gilmore (1999) generated a visual model where experiences are divided into four different categories: Entertainment, Educational, Escapist, and Esthetics (Figure 2). These dimensions are also known as "4Es". (Pine & Gilmore, 1999). Pine & Gilmore (1999) assume that tourism and hospitality experiences are built on two different perspectives: how much tourists participate in the experience (actively or passively) and what kind of connection they have to it (absorption or immersion). In the best case, several dimensions are activated at the same time, creating the richest and most memorable experience (Pine & Gilmore, 1999).

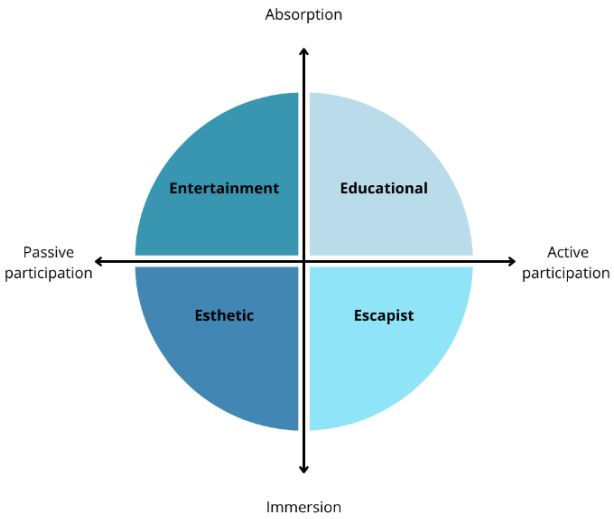


Figure 2. *Experience realms by Pine & Gilmore (1999)*

On a closer inspection, Entertainment is the combination of passive participation and absorption, and it is one of the oldest forms of experience. For example, listening to music or watching a play are examples of Entertainment. Passive participation is also part of Esthetics, but unlike Entertainment, the experience is associated with immersion rather than absorption. In this segment, tourists enjoy being at their destination without affecting it. This segment includes activities such as sightseeing tours or appreciating natural landscapes, where the level of environmental authenticity plays a minor role compared to the sensory and aesthetic

stimulation experienced during the activity. The third dimension, Education, includes active participation in educational experiences where the tourists absorb the surrounding events and are actively participating through their mind and body. Many tourist attractions, such as the Arktikum Science Center in Rovaniemi and the Siida Sámi Museum in Inari, utilize educational activities in their products, thereby increasing the knowledge of their visitors. The last dimension, called Escapist, refers to travelling where people want to escape their everyday lives through active participation and immersion in experiences where they can find something extraordinary and meaningful. (Oh et al., 2007) MacCannell (1973) argued that people who live in inauthentic and alienated worlds long for authentic experiences and therefore travel to other cultures and countries in search of authenticity. Especially, from an escapist perspective, summer cottages have provided a place in Finnish society where people can escape their daily lives in the cities and reconnect with nature and their cultural roots (Periäinen, 2004).

The Experience Economy concept is generally known in the tourism research field, and it has been utilized in numerous studies (see Table 1). Several research articles have examined the relationship of authenticity, experiences, and experience economy in different tourism environments and settings, and the table below presents some of these studies and specifies the findings concerning authenticity.

Table 1. *Authenticity & Experience economy studies*

Authors, year and origin of the study	Title	Aim of the study	Findings concerning authenticity
Chai et al. 2022, China	The moderating role of authenticity between the experience economy and memory? The evidence from Qiong Opera (2022)	Examine how authenticity moderates the relationship between Experience economy dimensions and tourist memory in intangible cultural heritage tourism	Authenticity strengthens the influence of experience economy dimensions - education, entertainment, and escapism—on tourists' memory formation and behavioral intentions."
Paulauskaite et al. 2017, The United States, United Kingdom	Living like a local: Authentic tourism experiences and the sharing economy (2017)	Investigate authenticity-seeking in the sharing economy (Airbnb)	Authenticity is an important part of experiential tourism; Themes (1) Interior and atmosphere, (2) interaction with hosts, and (3) local culture

Authors, year and origin of the study	Title	Aim of the study	Findings concerning authenticity
			were found to be the most important factors for perceived authenticity
Kirillova et al. 2017, China / The United States	Existential Authenticity and Anxiety as Outcomes: The Tourist in the Experience Economy (2017)	Examine how tourism experiences within the Experience economy framework influence tourists' existential outcomes—specifically, existential authenticity and existential anxiety	Tourism experiences significantly enhance existential authenticity, particularly when the experience is perceived as meaningful
Cornelisse, 2018, The Netherlands,	Understanding memorable tourism experiences: A case study (2018)	Connects memorable tourism experiences (MTEs) with authenticity in the experience economy	In the experience economy, tourists' search for authenticity does not only concern authentic objects, but also constructed authenticity in real places -> Authenticity is both object- and activity-related. Memorable experiences are highly personal and central to value creation
Domínguez-Quintero et al. 2019, Spain	The role of authenticity, experience quality, emotions, and satisfaction in a cultural heritage destination	Analyzes how authenticity (objective and existential) influences experience quality, emotions, and satisfaction	Both objective and existential dimensions of authenticity positively impact experience quality and tourist satisfaction
Domínguez-Quintero et al. 2018, Spain / United Kingdom	The mediating role of experience quality on authenticity and satisfaction in the context of cultural-heritage tourism	Examine how experience quality mediates the relationship between authenticity and satisfaction	Authenticity (objective and existential) directly and indirectly influences satisfaction via experience quality
Mody et al., 2017, The United States	The accommodation experiencescape: a comparative assessment of hotels and Airbnb	Expanding the experience economy model in accommodation	Serendipity, localness, communitas, and personalization represent valuable additions to the experience economy construct.

As the findings/summaries of various studies in Table 1 indicate, authenticity has a positive impact on experience quality and tourist satisfaction (Domínguez-Quintero et al. 2018; 2019). Both objective and existential authenticities influence customer satisfaction directly and

indirectly (Domínguez-Quintero et al. 2018), and memorable experiences enhance existential authenticity and are in great part in value creation (Cornelisse, 2018). Overall perceived authenticity strengthens the dimensions of the experience economy and the memory formation of a tourist (Chai et al, 2022). In the lodging industry interior, atmosphere, interaction with hosts, and local culture were found to be important in creating memorable and authentic experiences (Paulauskaite et al., 2017) (Table 1). Although the studies presented in Table 1 primarily focus on heritage tourism and various accommodation contexts, they consistently demonstrate that perceived authenticity is an important part of creating memorable and satisfying experiences.

Connecting findings from Table 1 to Pine & Gilmore's conceptualization of a successful experience, which is defined as "an experience that the customer finds unique, memorable and sustainable over time, would want to repeat and build upon, and enthusiastically promotes via word of mouth" (Walls et al., 2011), it can be concluded that perceived authenticity plays a central role in the creation of successful tourism experiences.

2.1.3 Evolution of authenticity theories

The term of authenticity was introduced by Boorstin in 1961 (Vidon & Rickly, 2018, p. 13) (See Table 2). Boorstin (1964) argued that tourism is a pseudo-event because modern life is full of inauthenticity, and tourists have therefore accepted this inauthenticity. He was criticized for his rather pessimistic and one-sided view that tourists were mainly motivated to travel because of their inauthentic everyday lives (Vidon & Rickly, 2018, p. 13). A decade later, MacCannell (1973) presented a more analytical view called the staged authenticity, in which people are treated as a unified group to which everyone belongs, rather than as a faceless mass of "tourists." MacCannell's view was based on the idea that tourism is a meaningful modern ritual where tourists seek to find authentic experiences (Uriely, 1997). He claimed that tourism experiences are not very often authentic but rather illusions or staged presentations of others' authentic lives. Later, the authors Cohen (1979) and Mkono (2013) criticized that both MacCannell's and Boorstin's perspectives were too simplistic and even somewhat far-fetched.

In response to MacCannell (1973) and Boorstin's (1964) objective views on authenticity, new theories emerged. While the objective view focused on examining whether the destination was real and original, the new constructive perspective considered tourist destinations to be authentic based on symbols of authenticity (Culler, 1981) or because of social construction (Cohen, 1988) (Table 2). Reisinger and Steiner (2006) describe that the base of authenticity is social or personal, and it is dependent on individuals' perception (Mkono, 2012). Wang (1999) adds that tourists with different backgrounds can have different meanings of authenticity, and the authenticity is defined by the individuals themselves. However, Wang (1999) criticized objective and constructive perspectives from the fact that they are only able to explain culture-related motivations and experiences, but not activity-related motivations and experiences. Hence, Wang (1999) introduced existential authenticity in the late 1990s.

Existential authenticity is based on the traveller's motivation to search for their true self through travel activities, without focusing on an objective perception of what is truly authentic and what is not (Wang, 1999). Wang (1999) divided the concept of authenticity into activity-related (existential) and object-related (objective and constructive) authenticities, and lastly, into post-modern authenticity. A good example of postmodern authenticity is Disneyland, which offers visitors a hyperrealistic or fantasy world experience that is deliberately inauthentic, but which people find more satisfying and stimulating than the real destination (Wang, 1999). Eco (1986) describes hyperreal as "a simulated experience that fulfils the desire for 'real". For example, when people are looking for enjoyment on their travels, such as wildlife viewing, they may accept "staged authenticity" as an easier and safer option and therefore go to a zoo. From a postmodern perspective, it is irrelevant what is authentic and what is not (Reisinger and Steiner, 2006). The chronological development of these authenticity theories is summarized in Table 2.

Table 2. *Development of Authenticity theories in chronological order*

Era	Type of authenticity	Key Theorists	Core idea
1970s	**Objective (theory)**	Boorstin (1964) MacCannell (1973, 1976)	Authenticity is based on the originality of objects, cultures or places.
1980s-1990s	**Constructive (theory)**	Cohen (1988) Bruner (1991)	Authenticity is socially constructed negotiated
1990s	**Existential (theory)**	Wang (1999)	Authenticity is state of being, self-discovery, and fulfilment through experiences, not depending on the object's "realness"
2000s – present	**Postmodern (theory)**	Baudrillard (1994), Wang (1999), Edensor (2001), Mkono (2013)	Authenticity is not defined because there is no original, only experiences exist
2000s	Experiential	Steiner and Reisinger (2006), Rickly-Boyd (2012)	Authenticity is based on lived experiences and in sensory and emotional engagement. It is phenomenological, not symbolic or external.
2000s - 2010s	Performative	Edensor (2001), Knudsen & Waade (2010), Mkono (2013)	Authenticity is presented, staged, and co-created with the tourists, hosts, and media.
2000s – 2010s	Psychoanalytic	Oakes (2006), Knudsen et al., (2016), Vidon (2019),	Tourism can temporarily reduce feelings of alienation and enhance authenticity. Authenticity is a fantasy.

More recent perspectives in 2000-century have expanded the key authentic theories (objective, existential, constructive) by adopting new perspectives to observe authenticity in various contexts. For example, Steiner and Reisinger (2006) focused on Heidegger's concept to analyse authenticity from intrapersonal (self-focused) and interpersonal (relation-focused) perspectives, and Rickly-Boyd (2012) examined authenticity based on Benjamin's theory of "aura," which connects rituals, authenticity, and individuals in an experiential context. Both perspectives (Steiner & Reisinger, 2006; Rickly-Boyd, 2012) are based on phenomenology, where tourists feel authenticity through embodied engagement.

The first approaches to performative (Edensor, 2001; Knudsen & Waade, 2010; Mkono, 2013) authenticity view in tourism studies emerged in the 1980s when Cohen (1988) spoke about performance mediated by culture. Edensor (2001) discussed tourism stages, how they are produced, regulated, represented, and maintained. He considered tourism a form of performance. Other publications concerning performative authenticity were executed by Knudsen & Waade (2010) and Mkono (2013). Knuudsen & Waade argue that authenticity is not just given, but it is relational, subjective, and represented. Mkono (2013) studied the significance of authenticity in African tourism and criticized the incompatibility of the theory of objective authenticity with Victoria Falls, which was the subject of her study. She emphasized aesthetics and artistic aspects as better alternatives than authenticity. Lastly, psychoanalytical views on authenticity, such as alienation (Vidon, 2019), and considering authenticity as a fantasy (Knudsen et al., 2016; Oakes, 2006) have been rising in recent decades to understand and explain the motivations of tourists.

As presented in Table 2, experiential, performative, and psychoanalytic views of authenticity have developed around the main theories of authenticity (MacCannell, 1973; Cohen, 1988; Wang, 1999), both as criticism and as a complement to them. However, authenticity is still a complex (Mkono, 2012), contradictory (Reisinger & Steiner, 2006), and dynamic (Rickly-Boyd, 2012) concept. This study focuses on Wang's (1999) perspective, where authenticity is divided into existential, constructive, objective, and postmodern views. The following chapter will examine these theories of authenticity and their definitions in more detail.

2.1.4 Wang´s authenticity theory

By the 1990s, there had already been a couple of decades of discussion about what is authentic and how it can be defined, for example, in the works of Boorstin (1961) and MacCannell (1976). Wang (1999) examined these views in tourism research and identified four theoretical approaches to authenticity: *objectivism, constructivism, existentialism, and postmodernism*. Wang was especially critical of views related to objectivism, i.e., objective and constructive authenticity, as they could only explain a very limited number of experiences. Therefore, existential authenticity was introduced, which was able to explain a larger number of experiences (Wang, 1999). Existential view has emerged as one of the most important perspectives on authenticity in tourism and hospitality research because it emphasizes people's desire for genuine and meaningful experiences rather than the authenticity of goods or objects. Next, these four authenticity dimensions are discussed in more detail.

As mentioned in the previous chapter, objective authenticity refers to observing objects, artifacts, and structures based on their genuineness. (Wang, 1999; Chharbra, 2008) This means that, defining something to be original, real, or genuine, it needs to be somehow certified, measured, evaluated, or approved by "experts" (Reisinger & Steiner, 2006; Chhabra, 2008). Objective authenticity is usually linked to heritage tourism (Domínguez-Quintero et al., 2019; Lin & Liu, 2019; Lee et al., 2015), where authenticity-related factors are considered to be essential. According to Chhabra (2012), even though objective ideas of authenticity are most prominent in cultural heritage tourism, the ways to verify authenticity are unclear and debated. Therefore, it is important to ask when utilizing objective perspectives, who is authenticating (Mkono, 2013), and whose benefit is the authenticity used? (Vidon & Rickly, 2018) MacCannell (2008) did not believe in authenticity, and therefore, he argued that in social life, inauthenticity or authenticity are not ultimate positions. He claimed that people are willing to believe that other people's lives are more real and that their lives can be transformed to a stage where other people can fulfill their dreams and desires (MacCannell, 2008). MacCannell (1973) believed that tourists seek authentic experiences and tourism is a modern and meaningful ritual to implement it (Uriely, 1997). Uriely (1997) criticizes MacCannell's (1973) and Boorstin's (1964) perspectives in that they treated tourists as a cohesive and homogeneous mass and did not consider the diversity of tourism or

tourists. Reisinger and Steiner (2006) also highlight another problem with the objective view of authenticity: it assumes that authenticity is an inherent characteristic of things and that everything is eternal and unchanging, which can be a challenge in an ever-changing world.

According to the second authenticity perspective, called constructive authenticity, tourists are not seeking objective authenticity, but symbolic authenticity built by society (Wang, 1999). From this view, ideologies and socially accepted norms are a base for socially constructed reality (Chronis & Hampton, 2008). Individuals decide what is authentic for themselves (Rickly-Boyd, 2012), and it does not depend on the originality or genuineness of an object, but rather on how objects are constructed by opinions, power, and beliefs (Wang, 1999). This means that constructive authenticity is built on the factors of tourism objects but also on the tourists' experiences and individual opinions (Belhassen et al., 2008). Cohen (1979) argues that tourists can change their opinion about authenticity from complete authenticity to partial authenticity and even to complete fake authenticity. Objects that become from inauthentic to authentic over time are called "emergent authenticity" (Cohen, 1988). A good example of this is an artificially generated Disneyland in the United States, which is nowadays strongly linked to the country's traditional culture (Reisinger & Steiner, 2006). Reisinger & Steiner (2006) also point out that hosts have a great influence on generating authenticity from a constructive perspective. This was also discovered in the studies from Paulauskaite et al. (2017) and Tussyadiah & Pesonen (2016), where they investigated how perceived authenticity is created in Airbnb accommodation, and one of the most influential factors was the interaction with the host. Since authenticity is also considered to be linked to locality from a constructive perspective, it is also included in the object-oriented perspective (Reisinger & Steiner, 2006; Wang, 1999).

As already discussed, Pine & Gilmore (1999) suggest that the current economical state is an experience economy, where people are longing for memorable and meaningful experiences. As object-related authenticity theories are poor at explaining the activity-based motivations, existential authenticity theory was introduced (Wang, 1999). From an existential view, the experience or activity can be authentic even though the tourist object is "unreal" (Wang, 1999). Thus, an authentic experience depends on oneself and one's personal judgment (Robinson &

Clifford, 2012). Wang divided existential authenticity into *intrapersonal* and *interpersonal* authenticity. Intrapersonal authenticity refers to an individual's bodily feelings and self-making, which means that the subject can spiritually and physically escape the routine inauthentic daily life through tourism activities. This eventually strengthens their self-realization, self-creation, and self-identity. (Wang, 1999) On the other hand, interpersonal authenticity refers to enhancing social relationships, emotional bonds, and authenticity inside the family and other communities at the same time with a pleasant experience (Wang, 1999). Steiner & Reisinger (2006) argue that existential authenticity is changing from moment to moment and is uncertain, due to its experience-oriented nature. Existential authenticity has been researched, for example, in luxury accommodation, hotels, and in the Airbnb context, where objects and items are not enough anymore but people seek memorable and authentic experiences in unique settings (Manfreda et al., 2024; Chen et al, 2022; Paulauskaite et al., 2017).

From the postmodern authenticity view, tourists do not care if a product is authentic or inauthentic, or they accept authenticity to be part of tourism marketing strategy (Reisinger & Steiner, 2006). Cohen (1995) argues that because people seek enjoyment, it is irrelevant if the experience is staged or the product is inauthentic. He also claims that the motivation to seek authenticity depends on the alienation in society: more alienated and distanced people seek authentic and genuine experiences when others are just seeking entertainment (Cohen, 1979). Wang (1999) argues that staged authenticity, with the concepts of "hyperreality" or "simulacra, offers more stimulating experiences. Eco (1986) defines hyperreal to be a stimulated experience that fulfills the need for "real", while simulacra refer to presentation with no originality, but which becomes real (Baudrillard, 1983, as cited in Vidon & Rickly, 2018). Some authors even suggest that authenticity is a fantasy (Knudsen et al., 2016; Vidon, 2017). For example, Santa Claus village is an inauthentic, artificially created, and imitated attraction where people travel to experience the nostalgic concept of Christmas, even though they know it's a copy and unreal. Santa Claus and Santa Claus village are both elements of postmodern tourism (Pretes, 1995). Postmodern authenticity is not a certain reality but an illusion of authenticity (Waitt, 2000)

2.1.5 Authenticity in Finnish cottage culture

Current research on authenticity in the accommodation sector focuses primarily on hotels and shared accommodation. Next, we will review these research findings in the context of cottage accommodation. Since many Finns rent out their cottages through various online services, such as Booking, Lomarengas, or Nettimökki, or through cottage rental companies, many rental cottages in Finland are privately owned. This means that they resemble a lot of shared accommodation businesses, such as Airbnb. In fact, Airbnb is one of the platforms that people utilize in renting their second homes during the season when they are not using them. Although Cabin accommodation in Finland is popular, the number of rental cabins is relatively small; in 2020, only 3% of all cottages in Finland were rental cottages (Official Statistics of Finland, 2020).

Paulaiskaite et al. (2016) conducted a study examining how perceptions of authenticity influence the "local" experience and its importance in consumers' accommodation choices, finding three larger themes that affect the traveler's feeling of the destination's authenticity. The first one was interior and atmosphere, which emphasized the features that the guest considered more home-like and real (Paulaiskaite et al. 2016). In a cabin context, this could be associated with traditional building style, cultural food and decoration, personal items, and the overall image of the cabin. The next arising theme from the study was the interaction with the host. The guests felt that the social interaction with the local hosts increased the feeling of authenticity, and they were able to gain a deeper understanding of the destination and their community (Paulaiskaite et al. 2016). In Lapland, cottages are usually rented through cottage rental companies, which means that the service is presumably more straightforward and automated than, for example, via Airbnb hosts. The final theme of the study was the interaction with local culture. In the study, the guests interacted with their hosts, which made them feel more connected to the local culture and see things they would have missed if they had stayed in a hotel. Overall, the study indicates that authenticity is not built only on objects in the accommodation sector but also on interaction with people and the surrounding culture. Similar results were found in Patwal et al. (2023) research, where they studied factors in choosing homestays and found that authenticity, "feeling at home", and connecting with local culture were key motivators for choosing a homestay over a hotel.

Several studies examined the relationship between authenticity and luxury accommodation (Manfreda, 2022; Hanks et al, 2024). Manfreda et al. (2022) studied how authentic experiences evolve in luxury lodges in Australia. They discovered that hosts and guests co-create authentic experiences together and that the minds and bodies play a key role in transforming staged experiences into authentic ones. Hanks et al (2024) found in their study that the focus in luxury settings has shifted from objective criteria to experiential criteria. Authenticity is seen as an important factor in the luxury landscape and creating memorable customer experiences (Hanks et al., 2024). Several studies have also explored the relationship between authenticity and shared accommodation (Paulauskaite et al., 2017; Birinci et al., 2017; Akarsu et al., 2020; Mody & Hanks, 2020). For example, Souza et al. (2020) studied customer experience, loyalty, place attachment, and perceived authenticity in peer-to-peer accommodation and found that dimensions of social interaction, aesthetics, and “escape” (known from “4Es”) influence most on perceived authenticity and enforce loyalty. Authenticity is also strongly tied to Airbnb's value proposition, as the accommodations are usually unique and personal and blended into the local landscape (Mody & Hanks, 2020).

In relation to interior design aesthetics, Enwin (2024) examined the importance of cultural heritage and cultural aspects and planning to create more authentic and meaningful environments that reflect the identity of communities. Material choices, symbolic elements, architectural styles, decorative motifs, and spatial arrangements are elements that construct the cultural identity of a site (Enwin, 2024). Wood remains the most popular building material for Finnish cottages, with around 70% of cottages being log houses (Puuinfo 2022; cited in Häkkänen et al., 2022b). On the other hand, the building style has changed from modest to more modern and larger, with better amenities (Häkkänen, 2022). One of the most modern forms of accommodation is glass igloos, where you can admire nature and the northern lights from your own bed. This type of accommodation has many features in common with traditional log cabins, but it has a more luxurious style. In Lapland's rental cottages, culture and nature are often emphasized through interior design elements and natural materials. For example, reindeer hides, furniture made from logwood, or paintings with Northern Lights may be part of the interior design. Although these elements are widely used in the interior design of holiday

cottages, their impact on the authenticity experienced by tourists has not been studied. It is also unclear whether tourists associate cottage accommodation with Finnishness and whether it reflects the country's cultural heritage for them, or whether it is just one form of accommodation among many others. Therefore, the following chapter discusses and explores the historical and cultural background of "Finnishness" to understand what Finnishness is and how Finnish national identity is formed.

2.2 What is Finnishness?

Finland is a small country with only 5.6 million people. The country's national culture and identity have evolved and been modified by meaningful events and collective memories, such as sport-related narratives and the Winter War (Finell & Liebkind, 2010). Finnish self-understanding has been connected to nature and agrarian values (Periäinen, 2006), including education-related values, work-related values, and honesty (Helkama & Portman, 2019). This chapter opens the concept of Finnish culture from a historical view and examines how Finnishness is seen and defined in the research literature. Additionally, this chapter will discuss Finnishness from a tourism perspective and what factors create Finnish culture from an international tourist's perspective. Since Finnishness has been studied relatively little from the perspective of tourism, and especially from the perspective of accommodation, the following chapter examines Finnishness from a broader, interdisciplinary perspective. Therefore, historical and cultural perspectives have also been included in the analysis to provide a comprehensive picture of Finnishness.

2.2.1 Representations of Finnish culture and identity

Only a hundred years ago, Finland was a very poor agricultural society with a long history between two powerful empires: the Kingdom of Sweden in the west and Russia/Soviet Union in the East (Paasi, 1996). Finland gained independence in 1917, and it was not self-evident who or what was considered Finnish in the beginning of building the nation called Finland. National identity, that Kristeva (1993, 58-9) describes as historically constructed memory, was debated

between Sweden, Russia, and Finland in early times (Harle & Moisio 2000, 96). In a short time, Finland developed from an agricultural society through industrialism to a post-industrial society (Tillotson & Martin, 2015). Paatela-Nieminen et al. (2016) point out that increased immigration to Finland since the 1990s has intensified the debate about who and what can be classified as Finnish. Overall, Finland has built its national identity relatively fast, in the shadows of two more developed countries.

Mindscapes that are built on culture, history, unique landscapes, and the characteristics of Finnish people are the base of Finnish identity. Appadurai (1990) defines mindscapes as dreams, memories, and personal experiences that manifest themselves in our imagination. In many Finnish art forms, themes such as forests, lakes, and the Baltic Sea are depicted repeatedly (Paatela-Nieminen et al. 2016), and they are also strongly attached to the Finnish national landscape. Edensor (2002, p. 40) notes that national landscapes are deeply shaped by ideology, influencing individuals' sense of belonging. Experiencing these landscapes, even briefly, can foster a form of national self-realization - a return to perceived roots through which the self is revalidated and released from its often inauthentic, urban condition. In music, Finnishness is often associated with people who like heavy metal and melancholic music with lots of minor chords (Kärki, 2021). Kristeva (1993, pp. 49–64) summarizes that in a plural society, diverse social realities are integrated into a unified national whole, which means that a wide range of fields and topics shape the concept of Finnishness.

Media, TV shows, and popular culture shape the picture of Finnishness. Dilley (1986) points out that movies and advertising shape the expectations of tourists. In the research by Aslama & Pantti (2007), Finnish national identity was observed in the context of survival reality television. They searched for topics related to Finnishness in the television program and found, for example, references to Finnish technology and Nokia, presentations of Finnish landscapes in national parks of Koli and Posio, and depictions of reindeer, the wilderness, and Sámi culture. The show was published in the early 2000s, which means that some new topics and themes have probably emerged to shape Finnishness in a new direction. Technology is still an important part of Finnish expertise identity even though Nokia failed on its own behalf in the early 2000s. Pietilä

et al. (2019) argue that Finnish engineering skills and describing Finland as a “land of technology” relate to the national myth and symbolism that Finns have a unique way to see the world, which makes them exceptionally skilled in the field of technology and engineering. Also, Finnish perseverance, known as “sisu,” was mentioned several times to depict the nature of Finnish people (Aslama & Pantti, 2007).

In contrast to its digital and technological advances, Finland is also seen as a rustic country with a simple way of life. Although Finland has become urbanized on many levels, Finnish culture idealizes and favors romanticized aspects of agricultural society and a simpler way of life (Tillotson & Martin, 2015). Tillotson and Martin (2015) explored the ways in which myth constructs and communicates the imaginaries of the Nordic socio-cultural region through advertising. They found that by using mythology in advertising, companies can capture and explain regional perceptions (Tillotson & Martin, 2015). For example, Finnishness was pictured in the adverts of Nordea, Isku, and Arla brands with themes of romantic nostalgia, idyllic and rustic lifestyle, key flag symbol, blue and white colors, arcticness, and bucolic way of life (Tillotson & Martin, 2015). For international consumer segments, these factors, such as idyllic images of the countryside and Finnish nature, create a sense of "exotic otherness" (Ger, 1999). The tourism industry uses this in place branding, for example, by creating a "winter wonderland" with Santa Claus or by promoting Finland as the land of a thousand lakes with its beautiful and untouched nature (Tillotson & Martin, 2015).

Schlesinger (1991) emphasizes that mass communication plays a key role in creating an image of the nation and its people as a close-knit community that shares common values. Media, advertising, and general discussion draw the picture of how Finnish people and culture are seen from a domestic and international perspective. For example, Hjelm et al (2017) found in their study that even educational books, such as language books, create a picture of Finnishness. They studied language textbooks teaching Finnish and found, for example, that Finnishness is rooted in stereotypes of nature-loving, modern, and progressive people who are also middle-class, white, and even conservative in terms of sexuality and gender equality (Hjelm et al. 2017). When tourists arrive in Finland, several factors are likely to influence their existing image of

Finnishness, such as where they have obtained information about Finland, what media they have followed, and how Finland is presented in their home country. What they perceive as authentic Finnishness depends on how they define authenticity and what sources they use to determine it. In the following section, we will take a closer look at various themes and factors that may reinforce the image of Finland among international tourists.

2.2.2 Elements of Finnishness from a tourist Perspective

This section examines the most well-known associations with Finnishness and the reasons why people travel to Finland every year. From a tourism marketing perspective, nature is closely connected to Finnish identity and Finnishness. A country with its thousands of lakes, Lapland as a magical northern region, urban cities with their easy access to nature, and the world's largest archipelago are themes how Visit Finland markets its nation (Visit Finland, 2025). With a long and rather recent agricultural history, it is no surprise that Finland and Finnishness are represented to the world based on its nature. Aro et al. (2018), who studied destination brand love in Lapland, describe that Lapland is associated with magic, mysticism, beauty, and unspoiled nature, and many tourists want to come to experience it and be part of it. For example, people travel to the Finnish ski center Ylläs to spend an active holiday and experience various activities, such as downhill skiing, cross-country skiing, winter cycling, mountain biking, hiking, and berry picking. (Aro et al., 2018). Nature-based tourism, which can be seen as including nature tourism, wilderness tourism, adventure tourism, environmental tourism, wildlife tourism, geotourism, outdoor tourism, and ecotourism, is growing year by year, and all the Nordic countries are part of this change (Fredman & Margaryan, 2021). For example, between 2015 and 2025, the number of visitors to Finland's national parks increased from approximately 2.6 million to 3.5 million (Metsähallitus, 2026).

The landscapes and high standard of living are strongly linked to wellness tourism in Finland (Business Finland, 2024), which has grown rapidly since the 2010s (Björk et al., 2011). Finland utilizes its scenic environments, such as lakes, as starting points for wellness tourism. For example, Finland has been voted the happiest country in the world eight times in a row in the

UN World Happiness Report, and one of the factors contributing to this success is said to be the close relationship with nature and the opportunities it offers for recreation and relaxation (Business Finland, 2024). Over the years, the Happiness Report has received international attention in various media, and it is also widely used in Finnish branding and tourism marketing. Nature and well-being are strongly linked in marketing, and Visit Finland (2025) advises on its website that happiness can be achieved by connecting with nature and local people, experiencing Finnish peacefulness, visiting a sauna, and watching the Northern Lights.

The sauna is one of the greatest national symbols associated with Finland globally. Historically, it has been linked to the concept of cleanliness and purity, but also to a mythological aspect. In Finnish culture, the sauna is, for example, described as a sacred place that embodies the power of nature. (Tillotson et al. 2020) Tillotson et al. (2020) propose in their research that sauna would be one of the symbolic resource discourses that shape the Finnish national picture and branding. For example, paintings and poems from the 1800s and 1900s shaped national sentiment and reinforced the role of the sauna as a mythical place and symbol of Finnish identity. (Särkikoski, 2012) Even though saunas are popular not only in Finland but also in other Nordic countries, they are strongly linked to Finnish culture and Finnishness (Tillotson et al, 2020). Johansen & Konu (2025) found that Japanese tourists travel to the Finnish Lakeland region to experience Finnish nature and Finnish smoke and herbal saunas. Overall, saunas play an important role in Finnish tourism, and Finland has many public saunas offering a wide range of sauna experiences.

Mythology is part of Finnish history and culture, and it is strongly linked to the Finnish language. Anderson (1983) argues that Finnishness emerged during the 19th-century with the rise of European nationalism, as the printed media and a common language strengthened collective identity. The Finnish people were long described as a forest folk, who lived among forests, lakes, and nature, and whose texts and even national song were written in Swedish (Tillotson & Martin, 2015). Finnish became the standard language in the 19th century. There was no high culture written in Finnish, but much of the Finnish discourse carried the atmosphere of Finland's backwoods roots, such as the Finnish national epic, Kalevala. (Tillotson & Martin, 15) Many

Finnish narratives contain mythical and romanticized elements of rural life, and they came to define Finnishness during urbanization (Tillotson et al., 2019). The Kalevala, written in 1835, is a Finnish artefact linked to Finnish nationalism. Its purpose is to remind Finns of their cultural heritage, and it contains several references to saunas, for example. Finnish Mythologies, such as the Kalevala, have been studied in the tourism sector in the context of marketing and branding (Tillotson & Martin, 2015; Pietila et al., 2019) and to understand the appeal of Kalevala-based products in global markets (Pulkkinen et al., 2023).

Another myth that attracts tourists, especially to Lapland annually, is Santa Claus. In 1980, the Finnish Tourist Board created a new marketing strategy program to promote Lapland as the home of Santa Claus (Pretes, 1995). An important milestone in the development of Christmas tourism in Rovaniemi was the visit by Eleanor Roosevelt, the wife of U.S. President Franklin D. Roosevelt, and the Arctic Circle Cabin built in her honor (Palo et al., 2020). Later, Santa Claus Village was built around this building and officially opened in 1985 (Herva et al., 2020). As previously mentioned, Santa Claus village is a good example of postmodern tourism, where the myth and reality are blurred, offering staged authenticity. Even though Santa Claus is in Finnish Lapland, it is not necessarily associated with authentic Finnishness. It is rather a tourist destination that offers experience and entertainment in a fantasy world with mythological characters.

The final topic in this chapter, Sámi culture, is rather controversial because of its complex and heavy history (Saari et al., 2020). Sámi people are the only indigenous people in the European Union, and in Finland, their homeland is situated in the northernmost parts of the country in Lapland's municipalities of Enontekiö, Inari, Utsjoki, and Sodankylä (Samediggi 2025). Sámi culture has deep roots in Finland's tourism history. For tourists, the Sámi people and their culture were major attractions, alongside the northern location, the Arctic Ocean, and the region's diverse nature activities. As a result, tourism soon became an important source of income for the Sámi people (Lüthje, 1995, pp. 25–26). Finnish tourism companies began to utilize Sámi culture and its elements in their advertising after World War II, but discovered at some point that the culture was not "visible" enough and therefore distorted cultural features to better

meet tourists' expectations and commercialized the original culture (Lüthe, 1995). As a result, the misrepresentation of the Sámi people and their culture has been widely criticized as unethical and unjustified. Sámi culture and the stereotypes associated with it are still strongly linked to tourism in Lapland today. The Finnish Sámi Parliament recommends that when utilizing Sámi culture in tourism, it is important that products are based on accurate and truthful information to ensure the vitality and authenticity of Sámi culture (Samediggi 2025). Ridanpää (2016) criticizes that people should be more sensitive and alert when reproducing stereotypical images of Sáminess, and he highlights that over centuries the picture about “nature-Finland” has been created by stereotyping, exoticizing, mystifying, and othering of Sámi minorities. Nowadays many Sami people are running or working in their own businesses and for example Jaakkola Reindeer Farm in Luosto is a good example how tourism, reindeer herding and Sámi culture are combined (Jaakkolareindeerfarm 2025). The Sámi Parliament (2018) of Finland has published guidelines for ethical and sustainable Sámi tourism (Saari et al, 2020).

So far, it can be said that Finnishness is an abstract and subjective concept. Every tourist arriving in Finland has gathered different information and knowledge about Finland, which complicates to create a consistent and universal image of Finnishness. Furthermore, the scarcity of tourism research literature on Finnishness makes it challenging to understand how Finnishness is perceived around the world and from an international perspective. However, previous articles have identified some common themes related to Finland and Finnishness, such as the importance of nature in people's lifestyles, leisure activities, history, and traditions. Finland is seen as an Arctic country with beautiful nature and a history that is reflected in both mythology and everyday life. The following chapter will discuss the historical and cultural background of cottages and how they could be related to Finnishness.

2.3 Historical and cultural significance of the Finnish “mökki”

From a sociocultural perspective, the terms "second home" and "cottage" are synonyms, and they usually refer to a privately owned building located in rural areas for recreational purposes, with amenities ranging from simple to very good (Hiltunen, 2007). Häkkinen (2022) notes that the word "cottage" has many meanings, ranging from modest lakeside cottages to luxurious villas, and that the term "second home" is more straightforward, usually referring to a well-equipped cottage that is used all year round. The cottage culture has its roots in ancient history, and over time, different peoples and countries have differentiated it. (Adamiak et al., 2015). Finnish second homes, or more commonly described as cottage or “mökki” (Finnish term), contains a similar history to other northern European countries, and nowhere else in the world are there as many cottage owners as in the Nordic countries (Müller, 2007) The first form of cottage culture emerged in the late 19th century, when the elite social class began to build summer villas and spend time in them (Pitkänen, 2011). The buildings were usually large, decorative, and placed near lakes (Vuori, 1966). Later, before the Second World War, a more modest form of cottage was introduced, which was both a lifestyle phenomenon and an architectural style (Periäinen, 2004). After the war, this form of cottage culture gained popularity among many social classes, resulting in *a mass phenomenon*, where cottages were built in large numbers as the living standards of the lower social classes improved (Pitkänen & Vepsäläinen, 2008).

About half of the Finnish summer cottages were built during 1970-1999, and today the number has stabilized at around 500 000 (Myllymäki, 2025). For example, in Lapland, the number of cottages has been rising steadily in 2000-century and many of them are constructed near tourism centers (Pitkänen, 2011). Müller (2004) describes these places, where cottage construction has been concentrated and which have become highly attractive areas, with the term “hotspot”.

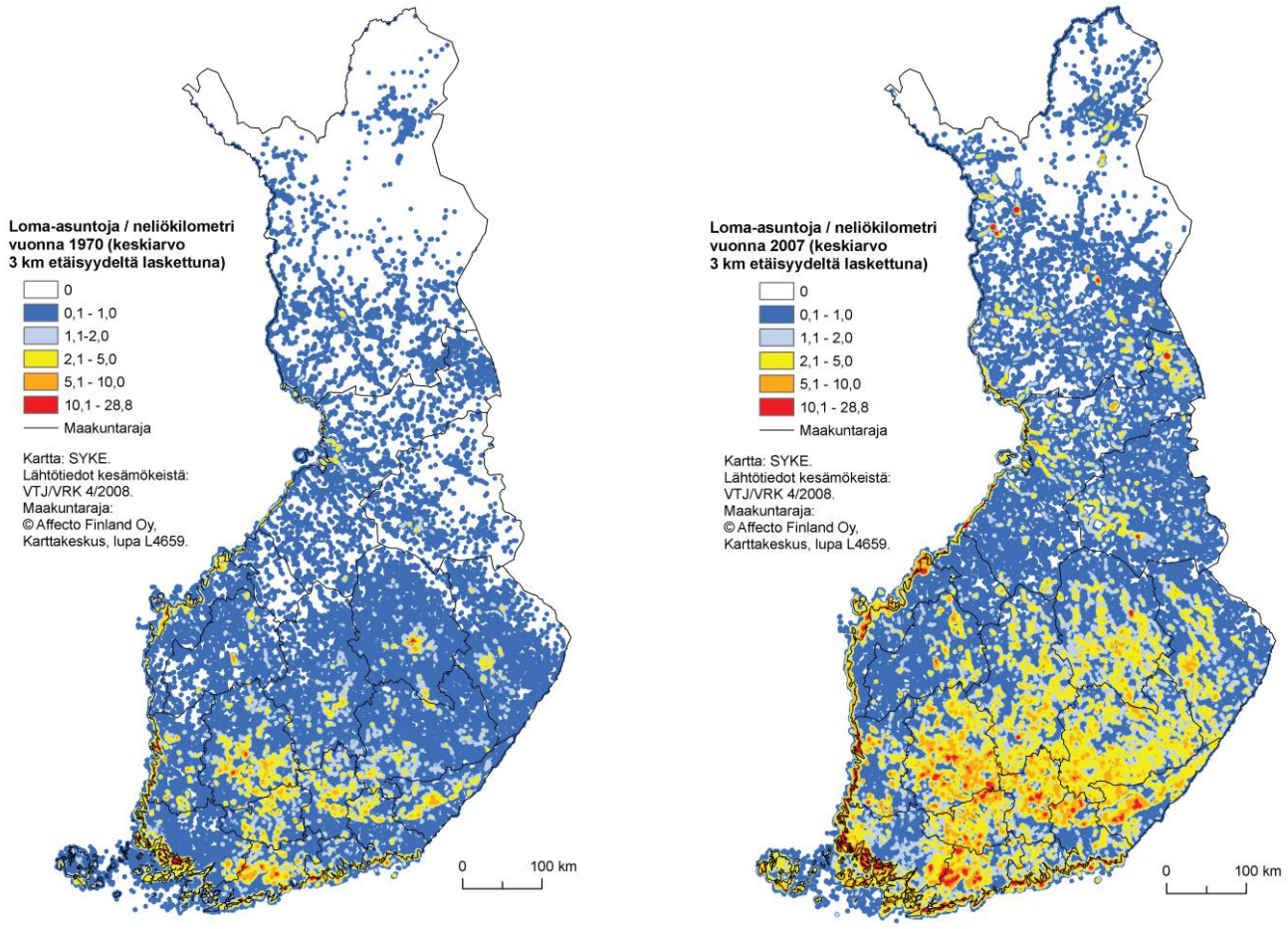


***Figure 3**. Regional distribution of cottages in Finland in 1970 and 2007 (Pitkänen, 2011)*

As the maps above show, the highest concentration of cottages has been built in the Lake District and coastal areas. In northern Finland, the number of cottages has also grown consistently, particularly in the tourist centers of Kuusamo, Pyhä-Luosto, Levi, and Ylläs. Pitkänen & Vepsäläinen (2011) specify that in tourist centers such as Luosto and Pyhä, cottage construction differs from lakeside construction in that the buildings usually form a cottage village consisting of single cottages, but also row houses, apartment buildings, and holiday shares. Adamiak et al (2015) emphasize that in rural municipalities, second homes play a great role in local economies, and they also have a significant business potential.

Wood has been the traditional and main building material for cottage construction, and its popularity has remained unchanged until the 2020s (Laapotti, 2020). Wood is a sustainable, natural, and ecological material, and because of the long history of log buildings in Finland, it is

associated with Finnish forests and nature in general (Lakkala et al, 2020). At the beginning of industrialization, log wood was used as the main material for constructing summer cottages and saunas (Häkkänen et al, 2022b). Many of the buildings in Luosto are log structures, which was the standard set by Metsähallitus in the 1960s for the style of facades in the area. (RKY 2009) Some authorities have outlawed log buildings in certain urban and suburban residential areas in Finland because they're so strongly associated with cottage construction (Periäinen, 2004).

According to cottage accommodation statistics from 2024, there were about 39 500 foreign overnight guests and 56 500 domestic overnight guests in the Pyhä-Luosto area (Visitor 2024). The research data was collected from local cottage rental agencies and online booking platforms. The most popular booking months were from December to March, and during the years from 2020 to 2024, the number of overnight stays increased steadily (Visitor 2024). The research indicates that cottage renting is still popular among both domestic and international customer groups (Visitor 2025). For example, in Lapland, there has been a strong investment in tourism and diverse accommodation options in the 2020s, from cottages to luxury villas. (Passoja, 2024; Rantala, 2024; Nuutinen-Kallio, 2025). According to Lapin liitto (2024), despite the economic downturn caused by the coronavirus pandemic, the turnover of Lapland's tourist centers, which include Levi, Sea Lapland, Pyhä-Luosto, Rovaniemi, Saariselkä, and Ylläs, has recovered, and the prospects for the future are optimistic.

Cottages and especially summer cottages are taught to represent Finnish national identity and have a strong connection to Finnish traditional lifestyle (Häkkänen et al., 2022b; Periäinen, 2004). They are strongly associated with myths and rural idylls, which are partly a result of urbanization and the previously mentioned longing for a romanticized countryside (Periäinen, 2004; Vepsäläinen & Pitkänen, 2010). Periäinen (2004) mentions that traditions, beliefs, and modern characteristics have blended in cottage culture. For example, building a cottage in the middle of a forest is more a romantic, international idea than a way of rural life from the past (Periäinen, 2004, cited in Linkola, 1981). Also, the typical architectural style, where the cottage is usually a log-framed, single-story building with a loft and a saddle roof that opens onto the shore, is not totally a traditional way of building Finnish cottages, but rather a common way of describing

national history by being connected to the forest and nature. (Periäinen, 2004). Staying at cottages is an important part of national folklore and identity, and from a tourism perspective, it is an opportunity to experience a Nordic way of life (Müller, 2007).

Summer cottages are also associated with Finnish myth. Barthes (1994) described that "The very principle of myth is to transform history into nature" and that anything can become a myth. He describes myths as semiotic systems; the summer cottage myth, for example, is a first-level sign to which additional meanings, such as national values, are added. In the context of the summer cottage, these can be beliefs that being Finnish means loving nature and longing for solitude. Therefore, the need for Finnish people to preserve a traditional rural lifestyle is linked to the summer cottage myth. (Barthes, 1994) Barthes reminds us that this does not mean that the enjoyment associated with cottage life in nature is unreal or somehow invented, because it is still part of Finnish heritage and traditions. The cottages enable Finns to return to their former homelands, as most of them are living in cities because of rapid urbanization. Poikolainen (2022) studied the attitudes of Generation Z toward cottage life. The results indicated that the younger generation is still interested in leisure travel to cottages and that the natural environment, outdoor activities, close family relationships, and a simple life are important factors for an enjoyable cottage experience (Poikolainen, 2022). This means that even though the cottage culture in Finland is associated with traditions and agricultural times in domestic tourism, it is still a popular way to spend time in the 2020s, and modern aspects such as technology and digitality are blended into cottage culture (Poikolainen, 2022).

2.4 Theory conclusion

This theoretical framework has introduced the latest research literature aiming to build a comprehensive picture of three themes: (1) authenticity in tourism research, (2) conceptualizing Finnishness, and (3) the history of cottage accommodation and its connection to Finnishness. Although Finnishness, authenticity, and cottage culture are all unique topics, they also share certain characteristics with each other, and they can be connected to each other. This study aims to find this connection.

Current research literature indicates that authentic customer experiences are one of the most burning topics in tourism research, and in the current phase of economic development, they have become even more important (Cornelisse, 2018). The Pine & Gilmore's experience economy theory (1999) represents the current economic development towards emphasizing the value of meaningful and personalized experiences and services, and that tourists are more aware of sustainability aspects and circumstances of local people in tourist destinations. According to the authenticity studies discussed in this work, customer satisfaction and authenticity are strongly linked together, and authenticity is an important part of experiential tourism (Domínguez-Quintero et al. 2018; Lu et al., 2022; Paulauskaite et al. 2017; Birinci et al. 2018). However, in the accommodation sector, the research field is rather narrow, and the discussion is mainly concentrated on hotel and shared accommodation forms such as Airbnb. After all, cottage accommodation is an important part of the Finnish tourism industry, and its role is especially significant in Lapland and Finnish Lakeland regions.

When discussing the concept of authenticity, it is important to acknowledge the long theoretical history of the term. Previous research literature has defined several theories of authenticity, and in recent decades, the number of authenticity studies has grown exponentially (Rickly, 2022). This study has outlined this development by focusing more on Wang's (1999) theory of authenticity, which is divided into existential, objective, constructive, and postmodern perspectives. These perspectives provide a useful lens for examining how authenticity is experienced in tourism contexts. Previous studies suggest that in the accommodation sector, perceived authenticity is shaped by various elements such as cultural and historical factors, interior design, architectural features, and interaction with the hosts (Paulauskaite et al.,2017; Enwin, 2024). In addition, Pitkänen (2001) highlights that while domestic tourism emphasizes experiential motives, the cottage landscape represents continuity and connection to tradition and nature.

The historical and cultural background of cottages is deeply connected to Finnish history, but also to the daily life of Finnish people. Cottage culture is reflected, for example, in Finnish leisure

activities, sauna culture, traditions, architecture, and mythology (Häkkänen et al., 2022a; Paatela-Nieminen et al., 2016; Tillotson et al., 2020; Pietila et al., 2019). By understanding the role of cottages in the Finnish mindscape and Finnish tourism industry, it is easier to connect the concepts of authenticity, Finnishness, and cottage culture to each other. In this work, "Finnishness" has been discussed as an abstract concept constructed through cultural and historical themes, which is also based on individuals' subjective knowledge and experiences. Since little research has been conducted on this topic in tourism studies, the research literature on Finnishness in this thesis has been cross-disciplinary. The next chapter will introduce the methodological part of this study and the background of the research site.

3 Methodology

3.1 Research site

Luosto is a ski and tourist centre in the municipality of Sodankylä, attached to the Pyhä-Luosto National Park. In 2024, there were 73 permanent residents in Luosto (Official Statistics of Finland, 2026). In 2025, Pyhä-Luosto national park was the sixth most popular national park in Finland with 199 000 visitors (Luontoon 2026). In 2023, the total number of overnights in Pyhä-Luosto was approximately 322 000, and the peak season is during the winter months from December to April. The most common nationalities of tourists include British, French, Dutch, German, and Swiss. (Summanen, 2023) In 2024, domestic overnight stays in cottage accommodation in Pyhä-Luosto were 56 467 and international overnight stays 39 530 (Visitory, 2025). Overall, the development of accommodation capacity has been increasing steadily from 2013 to 2023, despite the temporary decline due to the COVID-19 pandemic (Summanen, 2023).

The Pyhä-Luosto area was originally inhabited by Forest Sami, and for example, Pyhä Fell has been a sacred place for them. Since prehistoric times, people have been fishing, hunting, and gathering natural resources in the area. (Luontoon 2025) The unique and protected nature of Pyhä-Luosto has formed on one of the oldest mountain ranges, stretching about 35 km from Pyhä to Luosto (Luontoon 2025). The first tourists came to Luosto after the Second World War, and tourism and accommodation services began to develop in the Luosto area in the late 1960s (Luostoon, 2025). Yli-Luosto hut was one of the first buildings constructed for tourists in 1949, and it is still used by hikers today. By the 2020s, cottage accommodation had been developed to be one of the biggest accommodation forms in Luosto and Pyhä. The cottage village is located below the Luosto fell and is sheltered by an old pine and spruce forest and surrounded by marshes and wetlands. Especially in Luosto, traditional log wood cottages are an integral and recognizable part of the area because the façade style was standardized by Metsähallitus in the 1960s (RKY 2009).

3.2 Research approach

This study is conducted as qualitative research utilizing thematic analysis. The research aims to understand tourists' perceptions of authenticity as a subjective and experiential process, which has predefined the choice of qualitative approach. Qualitative data helps examine subjective perspectives when the hypotheses are absent and can rely on a relatively small sample size (Eskola & Suoranta, 1998). Since the aim is to deepen understanding of the significance of authenticity and national identity in the accommodation experience, qualitative research is appropriate for studying this topic (Eriksson & Kovalainen, 2017).

Semi-structured interviews were chosen as the data collection method. Semi-structured interviews allow for the preparation of ready-made themes for the interview, but also provide the opportunity to adapt the order and nature of the questions according to the situation. This is of particular importance when examining authenticity and national identity, which are subjective and context-dependent factors in travel experiences. The method produces systematic and comprehensive information and enables in-depth research into the topic from the participant's perspective. On the other hand, it also requires skills in interactive and effective discussion management. (Eriksson & Kovalainen, 2017). The main participants for the interviews were tour guides from Central Europe who worked and lived at Luosto during the winter season. This methodological approach allows access to the tourists' perspective through experienced professionals who interact with them daily and witness their reactions, questions, and interpretations. In addition, for information security and scheduling reasons, the interviews were arranged through a local company that collaborated with the guides. This made it easier to schedule the interviews with the guides than with actual customers. However, one direct interview was successfully arranged with a customer who had visited and stayed overnight at Luosto.

Thematic analysis was found to be the most suitable analysis method for identifying and classifying the rising themes, because the study aims to understand subjective perspectives (Braun & Clarke, 2006). Thematic analysis is based on a process that aims to identify, analyse and report themes within the data. It helps to understand the qualitative datasets by focusing on

recurring patterns and shared meanings (Braun & Clarke, 2006). Additionally, this study is followed by an abductive research approach, which refers to a process in which the everyday meanings and descriptions given by people lead to the formation of categories and thus create an understanding of the basis of the phenomenon (Eriksson & Kovalainen, 2008). The analysis examines national identity and authenticity mainly from an inductive perspective, because the coding process does not aim to fit into a readymade coding frame, or the researcher's predetermined analytical assumptions (Braun & Clarke, 2006). However, it is important to note that the researcher cannot separate themselves from their theoretical and epistemological commitment, as the data are not coded in an epistemological vacuum (Braun & Clarke, 2006). For this reason, deductive research ideology is also considered, as the study relies heavily on Wang's theory of authenticity, which includes four different themes of authenticity: objectivism, constructivism, existentialism, and postmodernism (Wang, 1999).

3.3 Data collection

The research was conducted in Luosto, a skiing and winter tourism destination. Semi-structured interviews were conducted in December 2025 at the beginning of the peak tourism season. Three of the interviews were conducted on site, two by phone, and one through Teams. All interviews were conducted in English. The interviews lasted between 28 and 47 minutes and were audio-recorded and transcribed. Table three presents an overview of the interview participants and key characteristics of the collected data. In accordance with research ethics, all participants are presented anonymously in this study, and they had the opportunity to withdraw from the study at any time during the process. In addition, they were informed with a cover letter about the background and objectives of the study, confidentiality and anonymity conditions, terms related to data processing, practical arrangements for the interview, and the researcher's contact details and the name of the supervisor. The cover letter also briefly explained the concept of authenticity (Appendix 3).

Table 3. *Overview of the Collected Interview Data*

Participant Group	Participant Code and Nationality	Interview Type	Duration	Date	Notes
Guide	Guide 1 Switzerland	Semi-structured (by phone)	47 min	18.12.2025	Fourth season in Luosto
Guide	Guide 2 Switzerland	Semi-structured (on site)	28 min	11.12.2025	Third season in Luosto
Guide	Guide 3 Switzerland	Semi-structured (on site)	44 min	17.12.2025	Second season in Luosto
Guide	Guide 4 Netherlands	Semi-structured (via Teams)	42 min	12.12.2025	Third season in Luosto
Customer	Customer 1 Switzerland	Semi-structured (by phone)	36 min	11.12.2025	Visited Luosto in 2024 for three weeks
Guide	Guide 5 Switzerland	Semi-structured (on site)	33 min	10.12.2025	Ninth season in Luosto

G = guest, T = tourist

Before recording, it was pointed out that there are no right or wrong answers to the questions, and that respondents could take as much time as they needed to consider the questions and return to their answers even after the interview. The interview questions were divided into six themes (Appendix 1 & 2). Starting with brief background questions, the interviews explored guides' understandings of Finnishness and cottage culture, followed by discussions on cottage accommodation experiences and elements perceived as authentic for international visitors. The interviews then focused on the concept of authenticity and the guides' role as cultural mediators shaping tourists' experiences. Finally, reflective closing questions allowed participants to share broader thoughts on authenticity, Finnish cottage life, and their experiences in Luosto. The tourist version followed the same question structure, which was adjusted to the tourist's perspective.

3.4 Data analysis

The analysis of the data includes four stages. First, Teams software produced automatic transcripts of the interviews, which were first read through, and any translation errors were corrected. Second, the data was read thoroughly to familiarize oneself with the text and obtain a comprehensive picture of the data. Third, the data were initially coded to recognize patterns and themes concerning the connection between cottage accommodation, Finnishness, and authenticity. Finally, the data were systematically coded, and eventually 41 codes were recognized. The generative AI application ChatGPT (version 5,3 used between 1 February and 15 February 2026) was utilized in the implementation of the study. The application was used to draft the code needed to clean up the material, which was then modified and specified by the author of the thesis.

To illustrate the analysis, the dimension *Authenticity through Finnish cottage living* is presented as an example in Table 4. The data was coded with the aim of identifying concepts related to creating authenticity and recognizing elements of nationality in cottage accommodation. For example, codes *sauna, fireplace, and deadwood, local foods and products, coziness and home-feeling as part of cottage living,* and *small-scale living* were identified. These codes were grouped into one sub-category called the *Core cottage element.* Finally, a main dimension, *Authenticity through Finnish cottage living,* was formed based on the subcategories, which were in this theme: *Simplicity and slower lifestyle*, C*ore cottage elements, Environmental elements, Authenticity through difference from home,* and *Adapting to Finnish cottage living.* Overall, six main themes were identified: (1) Authenticity through Finnish cottage living, (2) Authenticity through interaction with locals, (3) Tourist backgrounds shaping authenticity, (4) Imagined, symbolical, and constructed authenticity, (5) Emotional and transformative authenticity, and (6) Threats to authenticity. The findings are organized based on these themes.

Table 4. *Example of the data analysis focusing on the authenticity through Finnish cottage living*

Example from the data	Code in the data	Sub-category	Dimension
- "What kind of things remind you Finnishness in cottages when you're staying in cottage?" (interviewer) ***- "****Like the fireplace or the sauna. Woods like that. It's like either made from Kelo or that there's like a lot of wood inside." (Guide 4)*	Sauna, fireplace, and dead wood (kelo)	Core cottage elements	Authenticity through Finnish cottage living
- "Mokka Tupa is a very authentic restaurant with Finnish food, yeah, traditional food from all over Finland. So, they have the black sausages from Tampere and then they have some, some Karelian flatbread and some of these. Yeah, very pretty. Different different foods around Finland. " (Guide 1)	Local foods and products		
- And also, this idea of. Like having the old home in the forest like it's also like something which which is a dream of many people to have their own fireplace, your sauna. You can cook. You can be with your family. It's cozy." (Guide 1)	Coziness and home feeling as part of cottage living		
" I tried to explain that it's a little bit of the Finnish style actually, that you have multiple beds like in one room for them. It was too basic.... sometimes people really love when it's just small and old because they feel like it fits so well in the place like. "(Guide 4)	Small-scale living		

4 Findings

This chapter presents the findings of the thematic analysis. Based on the analysis, the chapter is divided into six identified and interconnected themes, which are discussed separately in their own subchapters. The themes describe how authenticity is understood through cottage life, interaction with locals, tourists from different backgrounds, symbolic and imaginary expectations, emotional experiences, and concerns related to the development of tourism. Table five presents the codes, subcategories, and themes that were identified during the thematic analysis.

***Table 5**. Overview of themes and sub-categories of authenticity in Finnish cottage experiences*

Code	Sub-category	Dimension / Theme
- Authenticity through a simple and modest lifestyle	Simplicity and a slower lifestyle	Authenticity through Finnish cottage living
- Sauna, fireplace, and dead wood (kelo) - Local foods and products - Coziness and home-feeling as part of cottage living - Small-scale living	Core cottage elements	
- Nature (such as snow and forest) - Physical/social space and quietness - Cultural elements (colors, materials, and interior accessories)	Environmental elements	
- Everyday cottage routines (how everything works) - Finnish cottage equipment (such as a drying cabinet) - Practical differences from home (such as limited storage space)	Authenticity through difference from home	
- Learning and adapting to the local lifestyle - Closeness to nature	Adapting to the Finnish lifestyle	
- Meeting local people - Finnish characteristics (shy and introverted nature, personal privacy, social	Encounters with Finnish people	Authenticity through interaction with locals

Code	Sub-category	Dimension / Theme
acceptance, helping others, genuine kindness, and independence) - Stereotypes		
- Activities with locals - Social gatherings, such as dinners	Shared experiences	
- Storytelling, music, and local knowledge	Knowledge sharing	
- Guides sharing information - Guides shaping experiences	Guides as mediators of authenticity	
- Bucket list motivations - Nature and experience-driven tourism	Travel motivations	Tourist backgrounds shaping authenticity
- Immersive tourism (feeling the local culture) - Length of stay influence	Deeper engagement over time	
- Nationality-based expectations	Destination expectations	
- Lapland as a magical place - Winter wonderland	Destination imagery	Imagined, symbolic, and constructed authenticity
- Iconic attractions (such as Northern Lights, snow, Santa Claus village) - Staged but meaningful experiences	Symbolic authenticity	
- Social media - Organized tourism experiences (such as welcome fire, Santa Claus meeting, husky safari)	Constructed experiences	
- Feeling calm and relaxed	Emotional responses	Emotional and transformative authenticity
- Memorable and unique peak moments	Peak authentic moments	
- Connection to nature - Sense of belonging to place	Connection to place and self	
- Personal transformation - Slowing down	Personal change	
- Downsides of mass and hype tourism - Fear of overdevelopment	Tourism growth	Threats to authenticity
- Loss of local character	Loss of authenticity	
- Desire for small-scale tourism	Future concerns	

4.1 Authenticity through Finnish cottage living

Five different subcategories were identified in relation to authentic Finnish cottage living. Simplicity and a slower lifestyle were closely connected to cottage accommodation and particularly to perceptions of Finnishness within the small village environment. Quietness and peace were also described as central aspects of cottage accommodation in Luosto, combined with surrounding nature and forest views visible from the cabin windows. One of the guides describes the Finnish relationship with nature and a slower lifestyle as follows:

"Maybe in the simplicity or like in the simple life, I mean it's absolutely not negative. But I think people up here just can talk about Lapland are like happy with few material things you know, it's more nature and being outside … but I think if you see how people live, it's just like basic. It's not in a bad way." (Guide 5)

Guides described how elements such as fireplaces, saunas, and small-scale living were an important part of the "real cottage experience". These elements were not seen as staged parts of the cottages but rather as part of everyday cottage life. According to one of the guides, authenticity was described as part of the local way of life and learning new local customs, such as using a typical Finnish drying cabinet for dishes and learning how to use heating systems and cottage equipment. In addition to cultural elements, the guides emphasized material and architectural elements, such as dead wood (kelo) and even its scent, which they strongly associated with Finnish cottages:

"…this kelo wood is something that's really Finnish for them. Also, the smell. "(Guide 2)

From an environmental and physical perspective, Finnish cottages were described as being located in the middle of the forest, where there is sufficient space and privacy, and where nature is closely connected to the cottage atmosphere. The guides describe the rooms and storage spaces as relatively small, and overall, the living conditions are on a small scale, which sometimes causes problems with customers. Interior design emerged as a somewhat contested element of authenticity. While cottages could be either modern or traditional, participants generally associated warmth, natural materials, and coziness with stronger expressions of

Finnishness. In addition, unique cultural interior design, with elements such as an open fireplace, wood as an interior material, or wall-hanging rugs, is seen as part of Finnish cottage design. Guide 4 describes the role of unique interior design of cottages as follows:

"I think the Finnish cottages is like that, that they're all different and that makes them authentic, I think…. And also I think it breeds Finnishness but, it depends on how you decorate it. "(Guide 4)

In addition, guide 4 mentions that too modern and clinical a style does not remind authentic Finnishness:

"Yeah, I think it's more style. Like if you have like really nice straight leather white sofa or something like really modern then for me it doesn't breed any Finnishness like authentic Finnishness anymore." (Guide 4)

Beyond physical features, authenticity was also connected to everyday practices and adaptation to local customs. Although the cottage environment is desired to resemble the atmosphere of home, authenticity was described as arising precisely from the encounter between differences: where to find the nearest grocery store, what Finnish products and local foods are available, and what the local lifestyle is like. The guide describes his role in guiding tourists through the Finnish way of life:

"So, we already give some information about how to use the keys, to take it outside after the sauna, for example, and when when they want to cool down or. What else? Well, how to get to the dishwasher ready. Yes, little things. Practical. Which exactly which are different to to Switzerland." Guide 4)

Part of the cottage's authenticity is also connected to snow and winter landscape with snowy trees. Personal privacy in one's own cabin and having distance to the closest neighbours were mentioned to be part of the Finnish cottage experience by the guides. One of the guides mentioned that sometimes customers have even got emotional and surprised when they have seen their cottage for the first time, and the images and expectations become reality:

"I would say, a former family from Switzerland. I don't know that the whole family was together and they entered the, and they were just, they were shocked. Like the total picture was, like, it was like in how you say it, in a book." (Guide 4)

Overall, authentic Finnish cottage life is a holistic experience in which simplicity, nature, cultural elements, and local everyday customs together shape visitors' perception of Finnishness.

4.2 Authenticity through interaction with locals

Authenticity experienced through local people consisted of four sub-categories. Guides described that some customers look for authenticity through interaction with locals, and therefore they attend to activities, such as dinners with locals or go to eat at restaurants, which are mainly popular among the local people, to gain a deeper picture, for example, of the Finnish food culture. Storytelling and music are also strongly associated with local people, and for example, traditional Sámi singing (joiku) and storytelling about the nature and history of the area are an important part of authentic experiences. According to one of the guides, being in nature, drinking local berry juice, and listening to local stories about fishing are important for tourists, and many times the authenticity comes from the things that locals also enjoy doing:

"I would say like they would just they like to go to an outdoor and drink a Berry juice and have an exchange with that local guy who can tell them some interesting stories about the forest or birds or hunting or fishing or whatever." (Guide 1)

In addition to the interaction with the locals, the guides describe Finns as being close to nature and having a slower pace of life than the people of Switzerland. They describe a more relaxed lifestyle and physical and social space as typical characteristics of Finns. Regardless of the strong stereotype that Finns are cold, distant, and not very talkative, the guide 2 points out that although Finns can sometimes be a little shy and reserved, they are extremely friendly and helpful people. Guide 5 also mentions that Finns do not ask many questions, but accept people regardless of their background:

"They don't ask any questions, but it's not that they are not interested, it's it's more the feeling of like OK hey, you are here. We like you how you are.... Or it doesn't matter if you are rich or poor or what you have been doing, or what your plans are. We just enjoy the time together and that's it." (Guide 5)

Similarly, customer 1 states that the Finnish guides seemed sincere, normal, and genuine, which was exactly what the customer wanted from their holiday:

"...they are very kind and and Finnish authentical and not so, not so, fake tourism smile..., they are so normal and friendly and quiet. And that is what I need when I when I go back, when I go to the holiday: normal stuff and people. So, then I'm feel like like a film. Yes. Not like a tourist." (Tourist 1)

Beyond the Finnish characteristics and interacting with them, guides felt that they also had an important role in creating authenticity. For example, sharing information and guiding people in the area builds authenticity, and people gain more knowledge of locals and their lifestyle. In addition, learning and adapting to live in a new environment is part of building authentic experiences.

4.3 Tourist backgrounds shaping authenticity

Guides observed that visitors' different cultural and national backgrounds influenced how they interpreted authenticity. The guides describe that most of their customers come from Switzerland, where people have a lot in common with Finnish people. For example, their motivation for traveling to Lapland is often based on an interest in clean and peaceful nature, small group sizes, space, and authentic experiences in the local community. In contrast, one of the guides describes how people from the United Kingdom, France, or Spain are more often looking for typical iconic attractions, such as husky and reindeer safaris, Northern Lights, and Santa Claus. Just touching the snow can be a reason to travel to Lapland. Similarly, Asian tourists were often motivated to travel to Lapland by the Northern Lights:

"I used to also look after English and French and Spanish guests. Yeah. And they have different expectations of their rolling day. So, I think like for the English, they rather do the Husky the reindeer and they want to see

Northern Lights and Santa Claus and that's it, but the Swiss people, they also come very often for two weeks because they want to, you know, like get the feeling for this place, the full experience." (Guide 1)

"...for example, English people. Yeah, they just, they never. They never saw snow in their lifetime before. So that's another point that they really want to touch the snow." (Guide 3)

In addition, travel time and length of stay affect the importance of authenticity. Guide 4 points out that for Swiss customers arriving on public holidays or during the children's winter holidays, authenticity is not necessarily the primary goal. On the other hand, Swiss people who arrive at other times of the year, such as outside of general holiday periods, tend to stay a little longer, are often repeat visitors, and are specifically looking for authentic experiences and want to learn about Finnish culture and nature:

"They want to do or see also these of authentic things. And for them, it's really important, I think they're not coming just for this really touristy things that you don't can do in Switzerland, they want to feel like also the nature they really enjoy the nature and also like to live a little bit Finnish up here." (Guide 2)

Cultural background might also affect the feeling of authenticity of staged travel destinations, such as Santa Claus village. One of the guides explains that authenticity is not necessarily something that tourists constantly think about and evaluate. They want to experience things that are typical of the destination, even though they would be staged:

"But still people come to experience it here because for them, it belongs to Lapland. Yeah. For them, it's some kind of authentic." (Guide 5)

Overall, people from different countries have different reasons, expectations, and motivations when it comes to travel destinations and vacation plans. The concept of authenticity is not necessarily shared by everyone, but instead it is shaped by the cultural background and individual expectations of travellers.

4.4 Imagined, symbolical, and constructed authenticity

The fourth main theme is divided into three sub-categories: destination image, symbolic authenticity, and constructed experiences. Expectations and destination images created by the tourist were described as important motivations for traveling to Finland, especially Lapland. In some cases, authenticity was described as arising when expectations and reality were consistent. When the cabins or landscapes matched visitors' preconceptions of Lapland, they experienced strong emotional reactions. Tourist 1 describes that part of her image of Finland as a white winter wonderland with snow-covered trees and a magical atmosphere. She described one of the most authentic and unforgettable moments as an emotionally powerful experience that was strongly connected to nature, silence, and the cottage environment:

"...I think it was a big fire moon in, in the colour like orange or, or like a red moon. And this moon was so big and behind and before it was a little cottage. And it was so authentic. And I saw this, and I remember then my tears, they are running over my cheeks. It was really emotional for me. This picture I never forget because that was in this moment so authentical Finnish for me...It was an authentic moment.... I'm sure it's all about this quietness and all together. It was so magic and all these little things, the magic moments. They are typical Finnish for me. "(Tourist 1)

Depending on visitors' cultural backgrounds, destination imagery was also associated, for example, with environmental aspects, such as seeing white snowy landscapes, touching the snow, or experiencing the iconic attractions, such as Santa Claus Village or watching the Northern Lights. Emotions play a significant role in experiencing the destination. Although images of magic, fairy tales, and winter wonderlands can be considered constructed representations, the interviewees described them as an essential part of visitors' perception of Lapland and thus important in creating authentic experiences. For example, Guide 4 explains that, alongside practical reasons, people also choose to stay in a Finnish cottage because it evokes the feeling of living in the middle of a snowy forest, almost like in an alternative reality:

“I think cabins are like, also again, what you see on pictures, you see the cabin in the in the snowy woods. It's kind of this fairy tale cabin that you probably want to have. So, it's really this cosiness and that feeling that it gives it to them.“ (Guide 5)

In addition, Guide 4 explains that even though originality is one remarkable factor when thinking about authenticity, it is more important to understand how the locals live and what their traditions and culture are. For example, using a sauna without understanding its historical and cultural background leaves the experience incomplete in terms of authenticity. On the other hand, staged experiences can bring a sense of authenticity if people identify them as part of the identity of the place or if they are not aware of what is culturally original. One of the guides points out that authenticity is not always the priority for all guests; rather, completing activities on their bucket list is often more important:

“Yeah, but I don't think that people think that far. Yeah, but it's just an experience that for them somehow belongs up here.” (Guide 5)

“...they want to have like this experience to be in Lapland, to have a lot of snow like the minus degrees the huskies, reindeer and stuff. Yeah. For them it's not really important to have to do some authentic things” (Guide 2)

Additionally, social media platforms such as Instagram and Facebook shape the expectations and build up the destination image. One of the guides points out that many visitors already have an idea of what the destination should look like and thereby choose their accommodation to also fit into that picture:

“It's just that's it's what they see on pictures. I mean, nowadays people just use the Internet and Facebook and whatever Instagram. So, they already have an idea of what, how it should look like and also reflects on in their accommodation.” (Guide 5)

In general, the guides found it challenging to determine whether certain activities or accommodation facilities were “truly” authentic from the visitor’s perspective, which highlights

the subjective and situational nature of authenticity. Thus, authenticity in this context appeared to be closely linked to symbolic meanings and imaginary representations, rather than merely historical or cultural originality.

4.5 Emotional and transformative authenticity

Emotional and transformative authenticity were closely linked to visitors' experiences of staying in Luosto. This theme consisted of four subcategories: emotional responses, peak authentic moments, connection to place and self, and personal change. Emotional responses were recognised as an important part of experiencing authentic Finnishness and the local cottage lifestyle. For example, Tourist 1 describes authentic Finnishness more as a feeling that evolves from the surroundings, such as snowy trees observed during a snowshoe walk and the peace created by the environment:

"we had the experience with the snowshoes… it was a lot a lot of snow. And the trees it. It was like an art…And all these trees they, they spoke with me like, like the ghosts. It was. No, it was incredible for me. So that is for me typic Finnish. So, I cannot so explain. Maybe I feel to Finnish air, or I feel to Finnish people. It's not so to make with the words or to do something activity. It's more a big feeling. And this feeling become more or more powerful in Finland in myself, because here (home country) I I'm busy. "(Tourist 1)

Also, the feelings of coziness, warmth, and a sense of home were strongly associated with Finnish cabins. In addition, the feelings of magic or surprise and excitement about the local lifestyle mentioned in the previous sections were recognized emotional responses and thus part of each guest's individual, authentic experience.

Another important aspect of emotional and transformative authenticity was the occurrence of unique and unforgettable peak moments. Whether it was having a Finnish sauna treatment, hearing traditional Sami music, or having real encounters with locals and their way of life, these moments contributed to the experience of authenticity. For example, one of the guides mentions that for him the real authentic experience was when he had the opportunity to have a real smoke sauna experience, where the owners also introduced the history and background of

sauna, and sang some traditional sauna songs about “löyly” (Finnish word for the steam rising from sauna stove). According to the interviews, these memorable peak moments are important in terms of emotions and atmosphere for achieving a sense of authenticity of the local culture.

In addition to emotional responses and peak moments, participants also mentioned a deeper connection to place and self, and personal transformation during the visit. Guide 1 states that she has seen several times how visitors’ tense and stressed appearance has changed to more relaxed and happier during the holiday. For example, she mentions that the change in the children can be significant during the first days:

“We had quite a few children, yeah, which were crying at the airport because they didn't want to leave. It was very interesting to see, you know, and even like teenagers, they arrive. They're not in a very good mood because they don't have Wi-Fi and they feel like it's cold and boring because they're teenagers. And then after 2-3 days, you see them, like doing snowball fight with the siblings and smiling. So, I think. There's definitely like something which happens inside the people here, because it's a very, very magical place. So, there is maybe some kind of change in in, I would say, so happening in people” (Guide 1)

The guide also mentions that the slower and simpler lifestyle in a cottage and nature-filled environment creates less pressure to focus on external and superficial matters, such as designing clothing:

“Here it's more like. You, it’s more, I don't know. Practical and like, yeah, less influence from outside, you know. And also, I think I, I I got like closer to nature. And I got more calm.” (Guide 1)

Also, the low number of people and external distractions lowers the feeling of stress and encourages visitors to enjoy the present moment more and connect to nature and themselves. One of the guides also mentions that staying in Luosto has changed his view of traveling: now he spends more time in one place and appreciates its original and authentic culture, rather than rushing to see as many places as possible. According to the guides, many of the Swiss customers are also repeat visitors because they enjoy the authentic, nature-oriented atmosphere of Luosto village, which is not overly commercialized. Overall, emotional and transformative authenticity in

Luosto and cottage accommodation was experienced through moments of connecting to surrounding nature, themselves, and a slower pace of life, which allowed them to feel relaxed and focus on the present moment.

4.6 Threats to authenticity

The final theme of the analysis concerned perceived threats to authenticity and the future of tourism. Some guides expressed concern about the future of tourism in Luosto and more broadly, in Lapland. As the tourism industry has grown rapidly during the 2020s, several concerns were raised during the interviews, including the potential loss of authenticity and fears of overdevelopment. A couple of the guides were concerned about the mass tourism that is happening in Rovaniemi, and the pace of new resort development has increased significantly in certain areas. Guide 3 was especially concerned that Luosto would have the same fate as Rovaniemi, and too many flights and visitors are coming to one place:

"I get angry because it's even more and more and more. So that's one point if it's possible, but Luosto should go on like they are going on. Going on like today, just not to to get more and more houses just." (Guide 3)

Another major concern mentioned in the interviews was the rise of hype tourism in Lapland. Social media encourages people to visit Lapland increasingly, but at the same time, the length of a stay becomes shorter. People follow trends and seek social media pictures, but the interest in deeper engagement with local culture becomes less important. The uniqueness and authenticity of destinations may be threatened when rapid development occurs during periods of tourism hype, profit becomes more important, and the local character of the destination disappears. One of the guides hopes that Luosto will remain as a small and authentic accommodation destination, and additional accommodation capacity will not be expanded in the future:

"Because from my experience this is a short term. This is like a moment where people are very interested. It's a hype, it's an Instagram. It's everywhere. So people want to come here, they want to have this experience, they want to take it off the bucket list. Yeah, but it's it's not the people which come here for 10 times, it's a different. It's a different approach and I think it's very unhealthy to even though there is still a lot of space, but I don't like

the idea that it's getting like really really touristy and I really pray that you are still is not building more infrastructure like big infrastructure" (Guide 1)

According to the guides, small-scale tourism helps preserve the authenticity and character of a destination and is considered more environmentally and socially responsible. Thus, maintaining small-scale tourism development was perceived by participants as essential for preserving the authentic character of Luosto.

5 Discussion and conclusions

5.1 Discussion of the findings

This research aimed to understand how authenticity is perceived in Finnish cottage accommodation through the perspective of international guides and what kind of elements construct this authenticity for international visitors in the Luosto region. The research was conducted by interviewing five international guides and one tourist, and then the data was analysed and divided into six broader main themes. The findings revealed that authenticity is constructed through interconnected dimensions, such as traditional Finnish cottage lifestyle, interactions with local people, different tourist backgrounds, symbolic and imagined destination expectations, and emotional and transformative experiences. Additionally, the threats related to tourism growth and overdevelopment were identified as linked to the loss of authenticity. This chapter discusses the role of authenticity and national identity in cottage accommodation through two predefined research questions, the presented research literature, and themes that emerged from the findings.

5.1.1 International guides' perceptions and interpretations of tourists' sense of authenticity in cottage accommodation in the Luosto region

The first research question in this study sought to determine how the participants interpret authenticity as a concept. The results show that authenticity in the context of Finnish cottage tourism is not limited only to objective cultural elements, but rather emerges through a combination of physical environments, social interactions, symbolic meanings, and personal experiences. Therefore, the results can be explained through the lens of various theoretical perspectives on authenticity in tourism, particularly the objective, constructivist, existential, and postmodern approaches proposed by Wang (1999). The table below presents the perceptions of authenticity identified in the research results based on Wang's (1999) framework.

Table 6. *Dimensions of authenticity identified in the study in relation to Wang's framework*

Wang's authenticity dimension	Interpretation in this study	Related empirical themes	Illustrative examples from data
Objective authenticity	Authenticity is associated with tangible, culturally grounded elements of Finnish cottage life and everyday practices.	Authenticity as Finnish cottage lifestyle; Interaction with locals and their customs.	Sauna, fireplace, traditional cottage setting and elements, local food, and everyday routines in cottages
Constructive authenticity	Authenticity is shaped by visitors' expectations and social, destination imaginaries and representations of Lapland rather than by objective "realness."	Perceived and imagined authenticity, Tourist motivations Symbolic authenticity Guides as part of building authentic experiences	Lapland as a "winter wonderland", expectations, destination imagery, and iconic attractions
Existential authenticity (intrapersonal/ interpersonal)	Authenticity experienced through emotions, personal reflection, and a sense of connection to place, lifestyle, and self. **Intrapersonal authenticity –** Personal feelings, such as relaxation during the cottage stay. **Interpersonal authenticity –** authenticity created through relationships with others	Emotional and transformative authenticity	Feelings of calmness, meaningful moments in nature, and personal change during the stay
Postmodern authenticity	Experiences accepted as authentic even when organized or staged, as long as they are meaningful and contextually appropriate	Staged but meaningful experiences	Santa Claus experiences, husky safari, and staged activities that still feel authentic to visitors

Although Cohen (1988) argued that authenticity depends on the originality of objects, the findings of this study suggest that while originality contributes to perceptions of authenticity, it is not a necessary condition. For example, the Finnish way of life and culturally rooted elements were seen as an important part of authentic Finnish cottage life, but the need for these elements to be "original" was not recognized. On the other hand, having, for example, a sauna and fireplace in the cabin were factors that were strongly associated with Finnish cottage culture, and therefore they increased the feeling of authenticity during the stay. Based on research literature, objective authenticity is generally more closely associated with heritage tourism, where originality plays a more essential role (Domínguez-Quintero et al., 2019; Lin & Liu, 2019; Lee et al., 2015) than, for example, nature and activity-based travel destinations. On the other hand, the results support the idea that objective items, such as interior design, building materials, or local

food, were seen as important elements of authentic Finnish cottage living. Similar findings were also reported by Paulaiskaite et al. (2016) and Patwal et al. (2023), who studied tourists choosing homestay or Airbnb accommodation rather than hotel accommodation. The results of this study are also in agreement with Enwin's (2024) findings, which showed that cultural heritage and aspects in interior design aesthetics are important for creating more authentic and meaningful environments that reflect the identity of communities. Overall objective elements are part of building the feeling of authenticity, but they do not necessarily have to be original.

In addition to objective authenticity, constructive authenticity was identified in connection to visitors' expectations for staying in a cottage, and the symbolic significance of Lapland. In constructive authenticity, society and its power, opinions, and beliefs construct the meaning of authenticity, which does not depend on the originality of objects (Wang 1999). The results are in line with this theory, for example, in situations where visitors have built images of Lapland and Luosto before their trip. For example, social media and destination marketing portray the region as a winter wonderland with snow-covered forests, magical landscapes, and atmospheres. Therefore, authenticity is constructed on the fulfillment of these expectations and created images. For many visitors, the idea of staying in a small wooden cabin surrounded by snowy nature corresponds with these symbolic representations of Lapland, and when the experience matches this imagined scenery, the accommodation can feel truly authentic and meaningful.

Another possible explanation for the symbolic meaning of Lapland may relate to Finnish mythology, although direct references to mythologies were not discussed in the interviews. As mentioned in the literature review, Finnishness, and particularly Finnish cottage life, contains several romanticized rural elements (Tillotson et al., 2019). In this study, Finnish cottages were often associated with being in the middle of nature, surrounded by silence and a magical atmosphere that can almost feel like an alternative world. In this sense, Finnish authenticity may also be perceived as imagined and atmospheric, detached from everyday life.

In contrast, Lapland's iconic attractions, such as Santa Claus village and husky safaris, play a significant role in shaping the destination image. Although these experiences may be staged or

not entirely original elements of local culture, they remain important items on many tourists' bucket lists as something very Finnish. The results support Wang's (1999) propositions that staged authenticity can offer visitors an escape into simulated realities that provide entertainment, enjoyment, and stimulating experiences. However, the findings also indicate that it is difficult to determine how authentic visitors themselves perceive these experiences to be. This observation aligns with postmodern authenticity, which suggests that some people favor staged activities and attractions that may not be "original" but are meaningful and thus create a sense of authenticity. Previous studies have shown that perceived authenticity can enhance the overall customer experience and satisfaction (Domínguez-Quintero et al. 2018; 2019), as well as with the propositions by Pine and Gilmore (1999) that people long for memorable and meaningful experiences in today's tourism field.

Another finding from the results is that the perception of authenticity is subjective and influenced by cultural background. Previous studies emphasize that authentic experiences depend largely on individual perceptions and personal judgements (Robinson and Clifford, 2012; Uriely, 1997). Uriely (1997) argues that tourists should not be treated as a homogeneous and one-dimensional group. This point was also recognized from the results of the study, particularly when discussing differences between nationalities and cultural backgrounds. For example, Swiss visitors were described as more nature and activity-oriented travelers, whereas tourists from the United Kingdom were more interested in staged and iconic tourist attractions, such as Santa Claus village and reindeer and husky safaris. These differences suggest that expectations and perceptions of Finnish authenticity may vary considerably among different visitor groups. These findings further emphasize the importance of taking cultural expectations into account when planning travel experiences, as authenticity can be understood in different ways depending on visitors' backgrounds and motivations.

In terms of existential authenticity, both intrapersonal and interpersonal dimensions were identified in the findings. Intrapersonal authenticity was identified in situations where the tourists reported feeling calmer, more grounded, and relaxed in the cabin environment. Several participants also described experiencing a deeper connection with themselves and nature

during their stay. One notable example was when a tourist described seeing a red moon behind a small cabin and becoming emotional because the moment felt deeply meaningful. This example illustrates how existential authenticity can emerge through emotionally significant experiences that allow visitors to temporarily escape their everyday lives and routines and feel a genuine connection to themselves (Wang, 1999). In addition, participants mentioned personal transformations they had observed in themselves and in other people during the stay, which is also considered a typical feature of existential authenticity.

Interpersonal authenticity, on the other hand, emerged in situations where tourists experienced meaningful connections with the surrounding nature, other people, and the cottage environment. These moments were, for example, described as "authentically Finnish," referring to the slower and more peaceful lifestyle associated with Finnish culture. Previous studies by Paulauskaite et al. (2016) and Patwal et al. (2023) report similar findings in the context of homestay accommodation, where social interaction and connection with local people, host, and culture contribute to a deeper understanding of the destination and its community. Similarly, Poikolainen (2022) also noted in his study that the Finnish younger generation associates cottage living with natural environment, simple life, and close family relationships. These studies support the idea that the "home feeling," which was also identified in the findings of this study, is an important factor influencing the choice of cottage accommodation and strengthening the perception of authenticity. Overall, the findings emphasize that the existential authenticity in the cottage environment emerges primarily through emotional experiences, personal transformation, and connections formed with nature and the surrounding environment.

5.1.2 Perceived elements contributing to an authentic Finnish cottage experience for international tourists

The second research question aims to understand specific elements that create an authentic Finnish cottage experience. Based on the findings, these elements were related to the natural environment, traditional Finnish cottage culture, emotional experiences, and the symbolic

meaning of Lapland. In the following section, the identified elements are discussed from a practical perspective and in relation to previous research.

Finnish cottage accommodation is strongly tied to the natural environment. Snow-covered forest, silence, and a peaceful atmosphere surrounding the cottage were key elements that made the experience feel authentically Finnish. In terms of the research literature, these elements have similar features to Finnish mindscape and national sense of belonging, as well as to Finnish identity as forest folk (Paatela-Nieminen et al. 2016). Additionally, a slower pace of life and connection with nature were seen as part of authentic Finnishness, and these have also been identified as factors contributing to Finland's reputation as the happiest country in the world (Business Finland, 2024). In addition, personal space, socially and physically, and a remote location of a cottage were features associated with Finnish cottage life and culture, and therefore important elements in building the authentic experience of cottage stay.

In the cottage environment, the most important elements building authenticity were sauna, fireplace, and Kelo wood as interior material. The finding is consistent with the previous studies (Tillotson et al. 2020; Särkikoski, 2012), which highlight sauna as a central component of Finnish cottage experience and an important element of Finnish national identity. However, an interesting finding was that fireplaces were also strongly associated with Finnish cottage environments, even though they are rarely discussed as an important element in the research literature. In addition to the sauna and fireplace, smaller items associated with Finnish practicality and home life, such as drying cabinets and floor squeegees for drying bathroom floors, were also an important part of creating authenticity. One of the key findings of this study is that creating a sense of Finnish authenticity involves maintaining a culturally faithful environment rather than modifying it too much for tourists. In practice, this means encouraging visitors to adapt to local customs and everyday practices. Previous studies have similarly emphasized the importance of interior design, atmosphere, and interaction with local people and culture in creating authentic and memorable experiences (Paulauskaite et al., 2017; Manfreda et al., 2024; Chen et al, 2022), which further supports the findings of this study. The

results of this study show that several physical and cultural elements within and around the cottage environment influence how authentic the Finnish cottage experience feels.

Another finding is that constructive authenticity was partly built on social interaction with local people and guides. Sharing local knowledge and giving practical advice increased the feeling of authenticity and made the experience more meaningful. This aligns with Paulauskaite et al. (2017), who found that hosts play an influential role in the perception of authenticity in Airbnb accommodation. Additionally, social interactions with locals, including hearing their stories about local lifestyle, history, or culture, were therefore seen as an important part of perceiving and creating authenticity.

The study also identified several threats to authenticity. Based on the findings, factors that may decrease the perceived authenticity of the destination or overall cottage experience are related to overdevelopment, mass tourism, and standardization. High tourist numbers or excessive construction are feared of leading to a loss of local character. Additionally, fast construction may result in cottages that feel impersonal and homogenous, which can negatively affect the sense of authenticity. These aspects should be considered when designing and building new holiday apartments and when finding ways to maintain the local spirit and cultural heritage in new tourism products. The study by Enwin (2024) highlights that by combining and using various cultural influences, space can be made not only visually appealing but also meaningful and engaging.

Studies show that travelers are increasingly seeking experience-driven and authentic experiences rather than commodity-based goods (Tussyadiah & Pesonen, 2016). This trend was also visible among the tourists arriving in Luosto. Elements that create unique and memorable experiences and emotional responses appear to play an important role in shaping perceptions of authenticity. However, at the same time, the concept of authenticity is still complex (Mkono, 2012), contradictory (Reisinger & Steiner, 2006), and dynamic (Rickly-Boyd, 2012), and eventually highly subjective. Therefore, identifying and defining the elements that determine Finnish authenticity or Finnish cottage culture is challenging due to individual differences in

expectations, desires, and perceptions. Nevertheless, this study identified six key themes that influence and shape the experience of authenticity in Finnish cottage accommodation. These themes can help accommodation providers recognize areas within their services and operations where authenticity could be strengthened and further developed.

5.2 Theoretical conclusions

Due to the limited number of studies conducted on authenticity in the accommodation sector, particularly in the context of cottage accommodation, this study deepens the understanding of the role of authenticity and national identity in the accommodation sector. Because previous studies have mainly focused on other accommodation forms, such as hotels (Mody & Hanks, 2020), Airbnb (Akarsu et al, 2020), and especially luxury accommodation (Hanks et al, 2024; Manfreda et al, 2024), this study broadens the understanding of how authenticity is perceived in rural and cottage settings. Furthermore, the roles of national identity and authenticity have not been studied in the accommodation context before. Earlier studies on cottage culture have largely focused on historical (Häkkänen et al., 2022a; Pitkänen, 2011), geographical (Pitkänen & Rantanen, 2023; Hiltunen, 2007), and other perspectives. Therefore, this study provides insights into how foreign tourists perceive the authenticity of Finnish cottage accommodation and how Finnish national identity is reflected in these experiences.

This study contributes to the literature in the field in many ways. First, it extends authenticity research to the context of Finnish cottage accommodation, which has received limited attention in previous research. As noted by Müller (2007), cottage accommodation is strongly rooted in national folklore and identity and offers tourists a way to experience the Nordic way of life. By focusing on this form of accommodation, this study provides a more detailed understanding of the significance of authenticity in the context of Finnish cottage accommodation in Lapland.

Second, it demonstrates the roles of Finnish cottage environment and lifestyle, local culture, symbolic meanings, and emotional experiences in perceiving and creating authenticity. In particular, the study highlights the importance of everyday domestic elements, such as the

Finnish drying cabinet, Kelo as building material, and the open fireplace, in shaping visitors' perceptions of authenticity. These findings suggest that even small and seemingly ordinary elements can play a significant role in creating an overall sense of authenticity.

Third, it supports existing authenticity frameworks by demonstrating the multidimensional nature of authentic experiences. Overall, the perceptions of authenticity discovered in the study can be identified from the authenticity framework by Wang (1999). The findings suggest that perceived authenticity in Finnish cottage accommodation is constructed through several interrelated themes that can be linked to objective, constructive, existential, and postmodern dimensions of authenticity. In particular, the findings concerning the influence of cultural background on the perception of authenticity can be linked to constructive authenticity. From this perspective, authenticity does not depend on the originality of an item, but rather takes shape through the individual opinions, expectations, and cultural backgrounds of tourists (Wang, 1999).

Finally, the work promotes discussion on the development of sustainable tourism by highlighting the threats that mass tourism and overdevelopment pose to the authenticity of travel destinations. Therefore, future research could explore how small tourist centres such as Luosto can be developed in ways that support local culture and ways of life while also improving existing products and services without losing their local character.

5.3 Managerial conclusions

This study provides several important managerial implications and practical insights for accommodation providers. One of the key objectives was to identify ways to utilize the uniqueness of cottage accommodation and its authentic Finnish characteristics in the development of services for international tourism. Additionally, the study aimed to offer practical guidance on how authenticity can be effectively emphasised and utilised in business operations. Based on the findings, the following approaches are proposed.

First, the findings suggest that maintaining the traditional elements of Finnish cottage culture, such as the sauna, interiors made of dead wood (kelo), and a simpler cottage lifestyle, is important for creating authentic experiences for international tourists. Although the cottage culture varies geographically, for example, between Finnish Lakeland and Lapland, it is particularly important to understand and emphasize the local characteristics of each destination in the surrounding environment, atmosphere, and way of living.

The second implication highlights the need to carefully manage overdevelopment and mass tourism. Tourism providers should avoid excessive standardization, as a too homogeneous or impersonalised range of accommodation options may decrease the perceived authenticity of the destination. During periods of rapid growth, it is also important to consider the sustainability factors related to business operations, environment, and the surrounding community, as well as to understand the short-term and trend-driven nature of tourism demand. In rapidly developing tourist destinations such as Lapland, business growth should not be pursued at the expense of losing authenticity; rather, it should be developed in a sustainable way that preserves and respects the surrounding culture.

The third insight highlights the need to encourage accommodation providers to emphasize natural surroundings, silence, and peaceful atmosphere in cottage environments, as these elements strongly support the perceptions of Finnish cottage authenticity. Natural elements are not tied to specific seasons, even though winter is the most popular time to travel to Finland. Therefore, greater efforts should be made to encourage travellers to experience cabin accommodation also during spring, summer, and fall seasons, especially in Lapland, where the peak season is strongly concentrated on wintertime. Cottage life is an integral part of the Finnish way of life throughout the year (Poikolainen, 2022). Therefore, this authentic cultural tradition could be utilised more strategically for marketing to international tourists, which could help reduce the seasonal nature of the tourism industry.

Finally, the last implication based on the study is to highlight the role of emotions and experiences during the cottage stay. As tourists increasingly seek meaningful and memorable

experiences during their travels (Pine & Gilmore, 1999; Tussyadiah & Pesonen, 2016) it is important to adopt a holistic approach to understanding which elements create the overall authentic experience in the destination. For example, by providing information about Finnish culture, sauna culture, and local lifestyle, visitors are able to enhance their understanding of the destination and strengthen their perception of authenticity. Instead of relying on superficial, symbolic elements, accommodation providers should strive to deepen their understanding of the destination's character and based on that, create authentic environments and experiences for travellers.

5.4 Critical evaluation and limitations of the study

5.4.1 Reliability of the study

The reliability of this study is assessed by evaluating the consistency of the research process, data collection, and analysis procedures. The reliability of this study is supported using a semi-structured research method, in which all participants answer the same questions but are also allowed to answer more flexible follow-up questions. Through careful preparation and testing of the interview questions, unnecessary and irrelevant questions were removed. In addition, the questions were reviewed with the thesis instructor before conducting the interviews. Another part of evaluating reliability was the data handling process. Recording, transcribing, and saving the data were planned and conducted carefully. The data processing is also carefully explained and presented in the work. Artificial intelligence was used as a supporting tool during the planning and analysis phase, in structuring the work, and in the initial naming process of the codes. However, its suggestions required critical assessment and checking of the sources. AI's suggestions did not replace the researcher's own analysis. This careful use of AI supports the overall reliability of the study.

Limitations affecting the reliability and consistency of this study may be a rather narrow sample size, subjective interpretations, language barrier, and the specific location context (Luosto). Since authenticity is a rather subjective concept and depends on everyone's worldview, the results may

vary significantly among people from different backgrounds. Furthermore, this study is highly location-specific, focusing on a single tourism resort whose characteristics play a significant role in defining authenticity. The language barrier during the interviews sometimes created challenges, since English was not the native language of either of the parties. In addition, as this was the first time the interview study had been conducted by the researcher, it may have led to human errors, such as a sense of urgency or a lack of time when answering questions.

5.4.2 Validity of the study

Validity generally refers to the accuracy of the selected research methods and whether they measure what they are intended to measure (Golafshani, 2015). According to Stenbacka (2001), ensuring good validity in qualitative studies is simple; since the main goal of a qualitative study is to understand the specific phenomenon based on the understanding of other people, good validity is built on non-forced interviews and strategically well-chosen participants (Stenbacka, 2001). These conditions can be considered to have been largely met in this study, which strengthens the validity. The semi-structured interviews allowed participants to express their opinions openly, which helped provide a deeper understanding of the phenomenon.

However, the validity of this study may be limited by the selection of participants. The study focuses on tourists' perceptions, which are primarily interpreted through the professional observations of guides. Therefore, it is possible that the results would have revealed new perspectives, and the saturation could have been better if there had been more tourists among the interviewees. On the other hand, the guides' extensive work experience and the knowledge they have gained over several seasons reinforce the validity of the study. Despite some of the limitations, the results provide a coherent and consistent understanding of the phenomenon and successfully address the research questions, which supports the overall validity of the study.

5.5 Suggestions for future research

While this study has offered valuable insights on cottage accommodation from an authenticity and national identity perspective, it also offers several suggestions for future research. As the existing research literature on cottage accommodation is rather limited and fragmented, further studies are needed to better understand the decision-making process behind the choice of cottage accommodation. Due to the geographical limitations of this study, further insights into this phenomenon could be gained by examining the role of authenticity and national identity in different surroundings, such as lakeside areas in Finland, where cottage culture is also deeply rooted.

Since the data saturation of this study was not entirely achieved, future research could expand the sample size to include more customers. This could provide some new perspectives on the perception of authenticity and offer new insights into how national identity is constructed within the cottage environment. Furthermore, focusing on certain customer segments may help to identify cultural differences and preferences when choosing or experiencing cottage accommodation. By utilizing complementary research methods, such as surveys alongside interview-based approaches, the dimensions of authenticity could also be explored at a broader level.

Finally, Finland is full of nature-based destinations, making it essential for individual tourism destinations to stand out while preserving their cultural authenticity. Therefore, it would be important to understand the holistic role of authenticity and the cultural background of different places. As cottage accommodation is a unique part of the Nordic way of life, its full potential in international tourism has not necessarily been fully realized. It would be valuable to examine the opportunities for developing a cottage accommodation business in Finland and explore strategies for attracting visitors to experience authentic Finnish cottage life beyond the peak seasons.

The use of AI: The language of the thesis was refined by using the suggestions from the AI-based Grammarly application (used on 18 April 2026).

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Appendices

Appendix 1. Interview questions (tourist guide version)

A. Warm-up / Background

1. Could you tell me a little about yourself and your work as a guide here in Luosto?
2. How long have you been working here, and what kind of visitors do you typically guide?
3. What do you enjoy most about living and working here?

B. Finnishness

4. What were your expectations of Finland or Finnish people before coming here?
5. Based on your experiences, what does "Finnishness" mean to you now?
6. What kinds of things remind you of Finnishness in cottages?
7. In what ways do you think the cottage lifestyle represents Finnish culture or identity?

C. Cottage Accommodation Experience

8. From your perspective, what makes cottage accommodation different from hotels for international visitors?
9. What aspects/elements feel unique or authentic for you in cabin accommodation?
10. What aspects of cottage accommodation do tourists comment on, react to, or find surprising? Was there anything that surprised you?
11. How would you describe Finnish cottage culture? How does it differentiate from other places you have visited, what makes it unique or authentic or Finnish?

D. Authenticity

12. What does "authenticity" mean to you in the context of Finnish cottage accommodation? How would you define it?
13. What elements (e.g., nature, sauna, silence, interior, activities) or moments in cottage life feel really Finnish to you or your customers?
14. How do you think international tourists perceive authenticity / real Finnishness in cottages?

E. Guides as Cultural Interpreters

15. In what ways do you help tourists understand Finnish culture or cottage life? Do you feel that you play a role in shaping their authentic experiences?
16. How do you usually introduce the cottage or local way of life to international visitors?

F. Closing

18. Has traveling to Luosto changed you in some way?
19. Is there anything else you would like to add about authenticity, Finnishness, or cottage experiences in Luosto?

Appendix 2. Interview questions (customer/tourist version)

A. Warm-up / Background

1. Could you tell me a little about yourself and where you are visiting from?
2. Is this your first time in Finland or Lapland? What made you choose this destination?

B. Finnishness

3. Before your trip, what kind of expectations or images did you have about Finland or Finnish people?
4. Based on your experiences, what does "Finnishness" mean to you now?
5. What kinds of things remind you of Finnishness in cottages?
6. When staying in a cottage, do you feel it reflects Finnish culture or identity? What makes it Finnish to you?

C. Cottage Accommodation Experience

7. How would you describe your experience staying in a cottage compared to staying in a hotel?
8. What aspects of the cottage have surprised you, impressed you, or felt unusual?
9. How would you describe Finnish cottage culture? How does it differentiate from other places you have visited? What makes it unique or authentic, or truly Finnish?

D. Authenticity

10. What does "authenticity" mean to you in the context of Finnish cottage accommodation?
11. Are there certain elements (e.g., nature, sauna, silence, interior, activities) that make the cottage experience feel more or less authentic?
12. Can you describe one specific moment when you experienced something you considered really Finnish?

E. Role of Guides & Interpretation

13. How have guides or hosts influenced your understanding of Finnish culture or cottage life?

F. Closing

14. Has traveling to Luosto changed you in some way?
15. Is there anything else you would like to share about your cottage stay, your experience of Finnishness, or what felt authentic to you during your visit?

Appendix 3. Cover letter

Dear Participant,

My name is Reetta Hannula, and I am conducting a thesis as part of my studies at the University of Eastern Finland, majoring in Tourism Marketing and Management. I am inviting you to participate in an interview for my research, which examines experiences of authenticity and Finnishness in cottage accommodation. The purpose of this study is to better understand the role and significance of authenticity in Finnish cottage accommodation and to enhance understanding of Finnishness from the perspective of international travelers.

Voluntary participation:
Taking part is completely voluntary. If you interrupt the study or withdraw your consent after the interview, the information collected during the interview may be used as part of the research material.

Confidentiality and Anonymity
Your identity will not be collected or revealed at any stage. All quotations used in the thesis will be fully anonymized so that no individual can be identified. All information you provide will be treated strictly confidentially.

Data Handling, Storage, and Deletion
With your permission, the interview will be audio-recorded for accurate analysis. All recordings and transcripts will be stored securely and accessible only to the researcher. The material will be permanently deleted after the thesis is completed.

Interview Practicalities
The interview lasts approximately 30-45 min and can be conducted online or in person. If you have any questions, I am happy to provide more information.

Thank you for participating!

With Kind regards,
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